

The ingredients of hyperraising*

Insights from Tamil

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Abstract

On the strength of novel data from Tamil, which notably lacks hyperraising but optionally allows (classic) raising, this paper argues against two prominent analyses of hyperraising – in terms of the Activity Condition and in terms of CP intervention – which, we will show, overgenerate the possibility of hyperraising in this language. In contrast, we show that proposals that seek to explain the availability of hyperraising in terms of the Williams Cycle (WC, Williams, 2003) acting in conspiracy with the Phase Impenetrability Condition (PIC, Chomsky, 2001, et seq.) accurately predict its absence in Tamil. Further independent empirical support for this line of analysis comes from Spanish, Tariki and varieties of colloquial English, showing that a hyperraised subject in these languages occupies a higher-than-canonical position that is at least as high as Spec, CP. On the strength of these findings, we propose that hyperraising is possible in some language L if and only if long subject movement can obtain in L without violating the PIC or WC, and the subject A-moves to an athematic position. A language that manifests hyperraising must conjunctively satisfy all and only these input conditions. Since there are many more ways to violate these conditions than to obey them, our proposal also predicts the crosslinguistic rarity of this phenomenon relative to attested cases of classic raising.

1 Introduction

This paper contributes to our emerging understanding of what makes hyperraising possible in some languages, and impossible in others. Our core thesis is given in (1):

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- (1) Hyperraising(-to-subject) in some language L is possible if and only if, in L :
 - i. long subject-movement can obtain without violating the PIC or the WC (or both), and;
 - ii. the raising predicate does not assign a θ -role to the moved subject, and;
 - iii. subject movement to its landing site involves A-features.

To this end, we present novel evidence from cross-clausal A dependencies in Tamil, supported by additional data, some of it novel, from a range of other languages.

1.1 Main ideas

We present evidence from φ -agreement showing that Tamil optionally allows A-movement of a subject out of a non-finite clause – i.e. classic raising. However, these same agreement facts, supported by additional evidence from scrambling, lead us to conclude that hyperraising(-to-subject) – i.e. A-movement of a subject out of a *finite* clause into a higher subject position – is ruled out. This is entirely unexpected under proposals like Ura (1994a) and Nunes (2008) which treat A-movement, including hyperraising, in all languages as being triggered by the Activity Condition; we show that Activity does not regulate possibilities for movement in Tamil, as attested by the fact that case-marked nominals can subsequently A-move. The absence of hyperraising in Tamil is also inconsistent with Halpert and Zeijlstra (2024) which proposes that the chief factor determining whether a finite clause XP allows or blocks hyperraising out of it has to do with whether XP itself is a candidate for such movement. But since finite CPs can never be sentential subjects in Tamil, an explanation for the absence of hyperraising in terms of CP intervention is ruled out. The Tamil data thus serves as a useful litmus test that helps us diagnose the crosslinguistic robustness and validity of these different approaches to hyperraising.

We next present a range of evidence from hyperraising varieties of colloquial English, Spanish and Tiriki (see Greeson, 2024a; Fernández-Salgueiro, 2005, and Johnson and Diercks, 2024, respectively) suggesting that the hyperraised subject in these languages undergoes A-movement to a higher-than-canonical position, i.e. higher than Spec, TP. In contrast, evidence from φ -agreement and clause-bound scrambling in Tamil strongly argues *against* the idea of a similarly high subject position in this language. We take this to show that hyperraising requires the presence of a high landing site for A-movement, at least in languages where subject movement would need to proceed via intermediate Spec, CP.

We propose that this requirement confirms the status of the Williams Cycle, as formulated in (2), as a core grammatical principle underlying cases of syntactic movement:

- (2) Generalized Ban on Improper Movement/Williams Cycle: Movement to [Spec, XP] cannot proceed from [Spec, YP], where Y is higher than X in the functional sequence. Williams (2003)

(2) states, informally, that movement from an embedded XP must target a position at least as high as XP in the next clause; this effectively ensures that any movement from Spec, CP should land in a position at or above Spec, CP in a higher clause. This contrasts with other approaches to movement (see e.g. Abels, 2007) that assume that movement must follow a particular order of operations (e.g. A before $\bar{A}$) but not in a way that is sensitive to the height at which these features are encoded. In contrast to these proposals, we show that height really does matter, following recent work showing similar height-based effects for other types of movement (Egressy 2023, 2025; Meadows 2024, Meadows and Yan 2025) and even non-movement dependencies like case assignment (Poole 2023).

Crucially, the WC by itself is not sufficient to regulate possibilities for hyperraising; rather, it must operate in conspiracy with something like the Phase Impenetrability Condition (PIC) which determines possibilities for intermediate movement to the phase edge. Overt reflexes of cyclic cross-clausal wh-movement in certain varieties of Tamil (Malhotra and Chandra, 2008) suggest that finite CPs are phasal; all movement, including subject A-movement, out of finite CPs must thus proceed via the phasal escape hatch in Spec, CP. This PIC effect acts in conspiracy with the WC in a given language to ensure that subsequent movement of a subject in intermediate Spec, CP must be to a position that is as high as, or higher than, Spec, CP in the higher clause.

Since, as mentioned above, Tamil lacks such a high landing site, hyperraising is correctly predicted to be ruled out. In a language where a finite CP starts out being non-phasal, as has been argued for Brazilian Portuguese (Nunes, 2008), or becomes non-phasal in the course of the derivation due to putative "phase-unlocking" (Lee and Yip, 2023), the requirement for a high subject position, imposed by the WC in (2), is waived since the subject moves in one fell-swoop from a lower position, i.e. Spec, TP or, in the absence of EPP movement, potentially even lower.

Finally, we show that, in addition to obeying the WC + PIC, hyperraising movement must also be a species of A-movement to an athematic position. We showcase the relevance of thematic factors by closely comparing hyperraising with finite control in Brazilian Portuguese and showing that the distribution of these phenomena is accurately predicted by the thematic status of the surface subject in each – thematic in cases of control and athematic in cases of hyper-

raising. We then demonstrate that the availability of a high landing site for a displaced subject in some language does not automatically predict the availability of hyperraising in that language. We illustrate this for Icelandic, a V2 language where subjects move to a high surface position in Spec, CP but which, nevertheless, does not allow hyperraising. We argue that this is because V2 movement in this language does not involve any A properties – it is strictly a case of A-bar movement. On the strength of these investigations, we arrive at the proposed input conditions for hyperraising given in (1). Per our proposal, hyperraising should be possible in some language just in case the independent properties described in (1) exceptionally intersect in that language. This, in turn, helps explain why this phenomenon seems, at least from the vantage point of our current knowledge-state, to be crosslinguistically rare, relatively to purported cases of classic raising.

1.2 Core assumptions, clarifications and disclaimers

We are working within the Minimalist framework which, among other things, assumes a Y-modular architecture of grammar whereby a "narrow" syntax module feeds into the interface modules of sound (PF) and meaning (LF) at the point of Spell-Out (Chomsky, 2001): henceforth, we use the term "syntax" to refer to this narrow syntactic module. We will also assume a maximally pared down set of primitive syntactic operations, namely: Merge (involved in structure-building) and Agree (involved in structure-modification). All syntactic movement is thus an operational composite, consisting of the sequential combination of Agree and (Internal) Merge (or ReMerge).

We also assume, as is standard, that there is a fundamental tension between syntactic relationships that exclusively target (clausal) arguments (so-called A-dependencies) – like raising-to-subject and -object, EPP movement, passivization, and object shift – and those that do not (so-called $\bar{A}$ dependencies). For instance, the two show distinct locality profiles – e.g. where the latter can cross finite clauses, the former typically cannot; $\bar{A}$ movement reconstructs for scope and binding while A movement does not, and so on; (see Van Urk, 2015, for a detailed comparison with relevant examples).

The classic approach to the A vs. $\bar{A}$ distinction (e.g. Chomsky 1981a) was a positional one: i.e. syntactic positions were intrinsically bifurcated according to whether they were A positions, i.e. could serve as the landing-site for A movement, or an $\bar{A}$ -position. The relatively recent discovery of hybrid A/ $\bar{A}$ effects in hitherto understudied languages has challenged the idea that there is a robust, clear and predictable dichotomy between A and $\bar{A}$ operations crosslinguistically. Crucially it has also argued against the positional approach to the A/ $\bar{A}$ distinction, since several well-documented cases of hybrid A-movement out of finite

clauses (see e.g. Fong, 2019, for discussion of hyperraising in Mongolian) involve movement into positions traditionally classified as $\bar{A}$ positions. A prominent emergent idea, in reaction to this challenge, is that the A/ $\bar{A}$ distinction should be recast in featural terms Van Urk (2015), Lohninger et al. (2022), Lohninger (2025).

This is the stance we adopt in this paper. Concretely, we will assume that A operations are triggered by an Agree operation that targets features belonging to the domain of clausal arguments, such as [D] (signaling nominal(ized) status), [ϕ], and/or Case features, with the precise choice of feature being plausibly parametrized across languages. $\bar{A}$ operations, in contrast, involve an Agree relation that targets more general features – which can, but crucially need not be, borne by clausal arguments alone – such as a [wh] feature, a topic feature, and so on. We also follow Van Urk (2015), Lohninger et al. (2022); Lohninger (2025) in assuming that a single head may probe for both A and $\bar{A}$ features, either sequentially or in conjunction. This accurately predicts the existence of mixed A/ $\bar{A}$ effects since any movement triggered by an A-feature is A-movement, and any movement triggered by an $\bar{A}$ feature is $\bar{A}$ -movement, regardless of which head (T, C, v , etc.) hosts these features.

Next, note that while we argue for the importance of the Williams Cycle, as formulated in (2), we do not propose to derive it from first principles, anymore than we propose to derive the phasehood (or not) of a given XP from first principles. Such an endeavor, while definitely worthy and ultimately necessary, lies outside the scope of this paper. We refer the interested reader to recent work in Poole (2023) for a possible way to understand (2) in terms of parallel derivations interacting with the Strict Cycle Condition (Müller 2014, Chomsky 1973 2001, a.o.), to Meadows 2024 for a refinement of Williams Williams (2003) Extension Requirement called the Featural Extension Requirement, and to Graf (2020) for a computational explanation in terms of monotonic functions between syntactic representations and crosslinguistically universal hierarchies.

Finally, where not attributed to a secondary source, the Tamil data presented in this paper is novel and comes from the native speaker judgments of one of us. Non-attributed data for Spanish and Brazilian Portuguese is also novel and comes from one-on-one elicitations conducted by the authors with native speakers of these languages.

1.3 Roadmap

The rest of this paper is organized as follows. Section 2 presents a brief theoretical background of raising and hyperraising, showing in particular how and why attested cases of hyperraising challenge canonical theories of syntactic A-movement. In section 3, we provide novel empirical evidence regarding the status of raising and hyperraising in Tamil, showing that while non-finite raising

is attested and optional, hyperraising is impossible. In section 4, we discuss the theoretical implications of the absence of hyperraising in Tamil showing, in particular, that it renders accounts of hyperraising in terms of the Activity Condition or in terms of CP intervention crosslinguistically unviable. In Section 5, we examine another prominent line of analyses of hyperraising in terms of the WC acting in conspiracy with the PIC and provide independent evidence from a selection of unrelated hyperraising languages in support of this approach. In Section 6, we show that an explanation in terms of the PIC acting in conspiracy with the WC accurately predicts hyperraising to be impossible in Tamil. Section 7 outlines our proposal for a crosslinguistically predictive theory of hyperraising and motivates the input conditions delineated in (1). Section 8 troubleshoots two possible counter-examples to (1), involving hyperraising-to-object and ν P phasehood but concludes that these can be reframed in a way that is compatible with our thesis. Section 9 summarizes and concludes.

2 Background

Both raising and hyperraising involve cross-clausal A-movement of a subject to a higher subject or object. The core difference between them has to do with the finiteness of the clause the subject moves out of. The former involves A-movement out of a non-finite clause (cf. (3)-(4)):

- (3) Masha tends/seems [_{TP} ~~Masha~~ to be happy].
- (4) I expect him [_{TP} ~~him~~ to be happy].

In contrast, the latter involves A-movement out of a finite clause (Ura 1994). Hyperraising-to-subject and hyperraising-to-object are exemplified in Spanish (5) and (6), respectively:

- (5) Juan y Pedro parece [_{CP} que [_{TP} ~~Juan y Pedro~~ son muy
Juan and Pedro seem.3SG [that [~~Juan and Pedro~~ are very
listos]].
clever.PL]]
'It seems that Juan and Pedro are very clever.'
- (6) Vi a María [_{CP} que [_{TP} ~~María~~ compró los panes]]
saw.1SG DOM María [that [~~María~~ bought the loaves]]
'I saw that Maria bought the loaves'.

Classic theories of A-movement have been fundamentally shaped by the idea that English displays a simple binary pattern, allowing raising but not hyperraising (but see Greason (2024b) for arguments showing that certain varieties of English may allow hyperraising as well). Such theories have thus been designed to

rule in sentences like (3)–(4) and rule out those like (5) and (6). This outcome was achieved through the implementation of different syntactic constraints, operating independently or in conspiracy with one another, like the Activity Condition (Chomsky 2001), the Ban on Improper Movement (BoIM henceforth, Chomsky 1973) and the Phase Impenetrability Condition (PIC henceforth, Chomsky 2000).

The Activity Condition, as formulated in Chomsky (2001) stipulates that an XP that eliminates all of its uninterpretable features in the course of the derivation is made ‘inactive, thus ineligible for further syntactic operations. In the case of A-movement (a syntactic operation), this is typically taken to mean that once a potential A-mover DP, e.g. a clausal subject, has been assigned Case (which, in a case-licensing approach, means that it no longer bears an uninterpretable Case feature), it may no longer undergo syntactic movement. It is further typically assumed that finite T assigns Case to its subject but that non-finite T does not and that such Case assignment happens as early as possible, prior to any movement of the subject from its case position. Taken together, this has the following effect: finite subjects are inactive for A-movement while non-finite subjects remain active for A-movement. This immediately predicts that raising, a species of A-movement, should be possible out of a non-finite clause but not out of a finite one.

At the same time, given that the idea of the Activity condition is itself not unproblematic (see e.g. Sundaresan and Zeijlstra, to appear, for discussion), it is notable that the same effect may be achieved without invoking Activity at all (*cf.* Keine (2018)), through a conspiracy of two other constraints, namely the PIC and the BoIM. The PIC says that once a phase head (e.g. C) is merged, its complement (e.g. TP) is spelled out, effecting its transference to the interfaces and rendering it inaccessible for any further syntactic operations, including sub-extraction. Consequently, movement of any material within the TP domain out of the CP phase must proceed via the phasal edge involving the head or specifier(s) of CP. This effectively reduces to a ban on fell-swoop movement in lieu of cyclic intermediate movement.

The cyclicity of $\bar{A}$ -movement, e.g. wh-movement, is empirically well-motivated, being corroborated by LF scope effects and, in certain languages, morphological reflexes of intermediate movement (e.g. Irish, McCloskey (2001)). For A-movement, however, the BoIM rules out the possibility of a PIC-obeying derivation. In its classic formulation, the BoIM rules out derivations in which A-movement follows $\bar{A}$ -movement, or movement from an $\bar{A}$ -position to an A-position (under a positional definition of the A/ $\bar{A}$ distinction, van Urk, 2015). Since (a) Spec,CP, the intermediate landing site necessary for PIC circumvention, is standardly assumed to be an $\bar{A}$ position and (b) the presumed landing site of hyperraised subjects, Spec,TP, is an A position, hyperraising via the CP phase should be impossible. A derivation that obeys the BoIM does so on pain of violating the PIC;

conversely, a derivation that obeys the PIC necessarily runs afoul of the classic BoIM. Hyperraising is thus ruled out, and classic raising is ruled in, as desired.

Not surprisingly, then, the (relatively recent) discovery of hyperraising in languages like Brazilian Portuguese (e.g. Nunes 2008), Zulu (Halpert 2019a) and Spanish (cf. Exx. (5)-(6)) has forced a fundamental re-evaluation of some of the core assumptions underlying classic theories of syntactic locality. Such modifications range from suggesting that the Activity Condition is notably absent in constructions or languages involving hyperraising (Ura, 1994b; Nevins, 2004a; Carstens and Diercks, 2013b) or that the PIC or BoIM are exceptionally circumvented in hyper-raising environments (cf. Nunes, 2008; Jenks, 2025; Lee and Yip, 2023, for PIC and Fong, 2019; Lohninger, 2025 for BoIM), to positing that hyperraising is fed by the absence of intervention for movement by the embedded clause hosting the subject (Halpert, 2019a; Halpert and Zeijlstra, 2024).

But as we will see, proposals in terms of Activity and CP intervention are not viable. For one thing, there is a clear theoretical redundancy in the nature of the proposed solutions involving the Activity Condition vs. the PIC operating in conspiracy with the BoIM (Nevins, 2004b) and the choice between the two often ends up being made on an aesthetic, rather than empirical, grounds. Furthermore, these proposals are somewhat parochial in nature – thus are not straightforwardly generalizable to other languages – having been motivated by the empirical properties of one or more specific languages. A final challenge to these proposals involves the core novel empirical contribution of this paper, presented in the section below, involving a range of evidence showing that hyperraising is notably absent in (Spoken) Tamil (Dravidian). As we will see, approaches to hyperraising in terms of Activity and CP intervention wrongly predict hyperraising to be possible in Tamil. The Tamil data thus showcases perhaps the biggest challenge surrounding such proposals, namely that they lack crosslinguistic predictive power with respect to this phenomenon.

3 Insights from Tamil

The novel empirical evidence presented in this section shows that while Tamil optionally allows (classic) raising, it bans hyperraising.

3.1 Relevant background

Tamil is a head-final SOV language, displays rampant local scrambling (Sarma 2003) and allows both subjects and objects to be pro-dropped (cf. (7) and discussion in McFadden and Sundaresan, 2018):

- (7) $\text{pro}_i \text{pro}_j \quad \text{pro}_k \quad \text{kud}i\text{-}tt\text{-}een.$
 (I) (the book) (to him) give-PAST-1SG
 ‘I gave the book to him.’

Like many pro-drop languages, Tamil also shows rich agreement; clausal agreement surfaces as one of many possible suffixes on the verb-stem; it reflects the person and number of a 1st- or 2nd-person agreement controller and additionally marks the gender of a 3SG controller. In Tamil, a language with NOM-ACC case alignment, this agreement tracks the φ -features of a nominative case-marked argument, if there is one, typically the subject (8). In sentences with a quirky dative subject and accusative object, where a nominative argument is entirely lacking, the clausemate verb shows default agreement which surfaces as non-covarying 3NSG (cf. (9) as well as Baker, 2015, for further data and discussion):

- (8) $\boxed{\text{Naan}} \text{avan-}\mathfrak{a} \text{paar-}tt\text{-}\boxed{\text{een}}.$
 I.NOM he-ACC see-PST-1SG
 ‘I saw him.’
- (9) $\text{En}\mathfrak{a}\text{-}kki \text{avan-}\mathfrak{a} \text{pidi-}\mathfrak{t}\mathfrak{t}\mathfrak{j}\text{-}\boxed{\text{id}i}.$
 I-DAT he-ACC like-PST-3NSG
 ‘I liked him.’

We will see below that where word-order fails, agreement comes to the rescue, allowing us to discern when subject A-movement has taken place.

3.2 Raising is optionally allowed

The main verb we use to illustrate the nature of raising in Tamil is *teri* (‘seem’) which takes a participial complement headed by *maadiri* (‘like’), yielding a clause that roughly means: ‘ARG₁ seemed like VERB-ing (ARG₂)’ (corresponding to the English: ‘ARG₁ seemed to VERB (ARG₂)’). The embedded participle, while bearing tense, nevertheless lacks agreement – thus, is defective for finiteness. Notably, there are two minimal variants to the resulting construction: one where the agreement on the matrix verb *teri* (‘seem’) matches the φ -features of the overt subject (e.g. 3MSG *avan* (‘he’)) and another where it bears default 3NSG agreement, as in (11):

- (10) $\text{Avan}_i \text{sandoo}\mathfrak{f}\text{am-aa iri-nd-aa-maadiri teri-n}\mathfrak{c}\mathfrak{s}\text{-}\boxed{\text{adi/aan}}.$
 he.NOM happy-PRED be-PST-PRED-LIKE seem-PAST-3NSG/3MSG
 $\approx$ ‘He seemed to be happy.’

We propose that the two distinct agreement forms identify two underlyingly distinct syntactic structures. The variant with default agreement on the matrix

verb is consistent with a structure where there is no nominative argument in the matrix clause for the verb to agree with, as shown in (11). Conversely, its counterpart with 3MSG agreement matching the φ -features of the overt nominative nominal *avan* ('he'), shows that the latter must itself be in the matrix clause, having A-moved here from embedded subject position, as shown in (12):

- (11) $[_{TP} \quad \text{Avan}_i \quad \text{sandoo\textsubscript{f}am-aa} \quad \boxed{\text{iri-nd-aa-maadiri}} \quad] \text{teri-nd\textsubscript{z}-adi}.$
 $[_{TP_{nonfin}} \text{he.NOM}_i \text{happy-PRED} \quad \text{be-PST-PRED-LIKE} \quad] \text{seem-PAST-3MSG}.$
 Lit: '(It) seemed like he was happy.' (Non-agreeing variant)
- (12) $\text{Avan}_i \quad [_{TP} \quad \text{_\textsubscript{i}} \text{sandoo\textsubscript{f}am-aa} \quad \boxed{\text{iri-nd-aa-maadiri}} \quad]$
 $\text{he.NOM}_i \quad [_{TP_{nonfin}} \text{_\textsubscript{i}} \text{happy-PRED} \quad \text{be-ASP-PRED-LIKE} \quad]$
 $\text{teri-nd\textsubscript{z}-aan}.$
 $\text{seem-PAST-3MSG}.$
 $\approx$ "He seemed to be happy." (Agreeing variant)

We thus take this cluster of facts to show that Tamil optionally allows raising-to-subject out of a non-finite clause, with raising feeding φ -agreement in the raised-into clause.

3.3 Hyperraising is disallowed in Tamil

Recall that, unlike in English, surface word-order is not a reliable diagnostic for raising in Tamil, given that it is head-final and that both scrambling and pro-drop are rampant. But agreement is: raising feeds agreement, as we have just seen, allowing us to test whether raising has occurred based on the agreement that surfaces on the matrix verb (cf. agreeing (12) vs. non-agreeing (11)). If hyperraising also feeds agreement, we predict that this distinction should again be similarly discernible. Concretely, the agreement on the superordinate verb should track the φ -features of the hyperraised subject. If, however, hyperraising is impossible in Tamil, then the agreement on the superordinate verb must bear default 3MSG agreement.

We put these predictions to the test by having our raising verb *teri* take a fully fledged finite clausal complement which minimally varies from its participial complement in (11)-(12) in the following respects: in contrast to the latter, which involve a participle which only bears tense, the embedded clause in the hyperraised variant is built on a fully fledged finite verb which bears tense and agreement as well as an overt complementizer.¹ The results of this test are very clear: only the construction with default agreement on the matrix verb is licit

¹The differences are as tabulated below:

i. Contrast in embedded verb-forms (non-finite vs. finite):

(13a); the one with agreement that matches the φ -features of the overt subject is not (13b):

(13) Absence of hyperraising out of finite CP:

- a. $[_{CP} \text{Avan}_i \text{ sandoo}\text{ḻam-aa} \boxed{\text{iri-nd-aaḻ-gir-aa-maadiri}}]$
 $[_{CP} \text{he.NOM}_i \text{ happy-PRED} \text{ be-ASP-3MSG-COMP-PRED-LIKE}]$
teri-ndḻ-adi.
 seem-PAST-3NSG.
 ‘It seemed like he is going to be happy.’
- b. * $\text{Avan}_i \text{ } [_{CP} \text{ } _i \text{ sandoo}\text{ḻam-aa} \boxed{\text{iri-nd-aaḻ-gir-aa-maadiri}}]$
 $\text{he.NOM}_i \text{ } [_{CP} \text{ } _i \text{ happy-PRED} \text{ be-ASP-3MSG-COMP-PRED-LIKE}]$
teri-ndḻ-aan.
 seem-PAST-3MSG.
 Lit: ‘He seemed like was happy.’ Intended: ‘Avan seemed to be happy.’

The ungrammaticality of the agreeing variant in (13b), contrasted with the grammaticality of a classic raising construction as in (12), shows that hyperraising an embedded subject with concomitant subject agreement on the matrix verb is ruled out in Tamil.

4 Theoretical implications

In this section, we will review two prominent approaches to hyperraising in the literature, one involving the Activity Condition and the other in terms of CP-intervention, and show that the impossibility of hyperraising in Tamil is unexpected under both. The Tamil data thus serves as a litmus test for the validity and predictive power of different approaches allowing us to distill the ones that work from those that do not.

4.1 Accounts based on Activity

The crux of the different strands of argumentation collected under this umbrella is that a (case-marked) subject, in a given language or a given construction, may

Semi-finite verb	V-TNS-PRED-LIKE	<i>iri-nd-aa-maadiri</i> be-PST-PRED-LIKE ≈ ‘been like’
Fully finite verb	V-TNS-AGR-COMP-PRED-LIKE	<i>iri-nd-aaḻ-gir-aa-maadiri</i> be-PST-3MSG-COMP-PRED-LIKE ≈ ‘he was like’

hyperraise just in case the subject somehow circumvents the Activity Condition, e.g. because the Activity Condition simply doesn't apply in the relevant language or clausal environment. We present the details of this approach here and then show that it cannot work for Tamil given, among other reasons, the possibility that a case-bearing subject may undergo raising in this language.

4.1.1 The argument(s) from Activity

If A-movement is constrained such that nominals become ineligible for A-movement immediately upon being assigned Case, then hyperraising of Case-marked subjects should be banned. The existence of hyperraising thus requires either (i) eliminating Activity as a syntactic constraint altogether, or (ii) saying that Activity is crosslinguistically parametrized, being simply inapplicable in languages with hyperraising, (iii) assuming Activity *is* valid cross-linguistically, but that there are independent, exceptional reasons why it doesn't apply in hyperraising constructions, e.g. because the finite embedded subject doesn't receive Case, in the first place.

Regarding (i), Nevins (2004b) raises a number of empirical and theoretical motivations for discarding the Activity Condition altogether: on the empirical side, the existence of subjects assigned non-nominative structural case in a number of languages, e.g. Russian accusative subjects Bailyn (2004); on the theoretical side, Nevins points to the fact that the Activity Condition is ruled at least partially redundant by the PIC and the Ban on Improper Movement.²

A notable case of (ii) comes from the Bantu literature, where Carstens (2011), Carstens and Diercks (2013a), Halpert (2019a) and others argue Activity is crosslinguistically parametrized and inactive in Bantu. Support for this conclusion comes from data showing that A-movement is possible out of finite clauses in this language. Such movement includes, but is not limited to, object movement to Spec,TP (Ndayiragije 1999), promotion of locatives to Spec,TP in transitive clauses (Kinyalolo 1991), and hyperraising (Carstens 2011, Carstens and Diercks 2013a, Halpert 2019a, and many others).

Turning now to (iii), approaches that assume the Activity Condition but find principled ways to prevent its application in hyperraising constructions include Ura (1994a) and Nunes (2008). The analysis in Ura (1994a) exploits the fact that all hyperraising languages in his dataset allow *pro*-drop. The author reasons that, under the traditional Case Filter, only overt DPs are required to bear Case, so a *pro*-drop language is one in which T may optionally not assign Case, leaving open the possibility of hyperraising. For Brazilian Portuguese, Nunes (2008) ar-

²Here, we should also note that the tension between Activity and the full range of attested A-movement data is not limited to hyperraising, but also extends to phenomena like (A-)scrambling. In languages such as Hindi-Urdu, case-marked arguments undergo a type of A-movement.

gues that certain TPs in the language are φ -impoverished in such a way that they are unable to assign nominative Case altogether, leaving their subjects active for A-movement. Potential support for this position comes from the fact that hyper-raising is degraded or impossible in Brazilian Portuguese when the embedded verb expones 1PL morphology (14a), but is possible when the embedded verb realizes person-underspecified PL morphology (14b). Notably, there is no such asymmetry when raising out of infinitival complements (14c–14d).

(14) Raising/hyperraising asymmetries in BrPt (Nunes 2008)

- a. *Nós parece-mos [_{CP} que esta-mos doente-s].
1PL.NOM seem-1PL [_{CP} that be-1PL sick-PL]
Intended: “We seem to be sick.”
- b. { Eles / vocês } parece-m [_{CP} que est-ão doente-s].
{ 3-PL / 2-PL } seem-PL [_{CP} that be-PL sick-PL].
“They / you.PL seem to be sick.”
- c. Nós parece-mos esta-r doente-s.
1PL.NOM seem-1PL be-INF sick-PL
“We seem to be sick.”
- d. { Eles / vocês } parece-m esta-r doente-s.
{ 3-PL / 2-PL } seem-PL be-INF sick-PL
“They / you.PL seem to be sick.”

4.1.2 Against Activity: the challenge from Tamil

Approaches based on the premise that Activity is universally valid are unviable for Tamil. To start, the Ura (1994a)’s approach to *pro*-drop and the Activity Condition will not work. While Ura’s proposal captures an apparent typological connection between *pro*-drop and hyperraising, Tamil shows that *pro*-drop cannot be a sufficient condition for licensing hyperraising—subject omission is widespread in Tamil (cf. (7)) despite a lack of hyperraising.³ The φ -defectivity approach to Activity in Nunes (2008) also cannot be straightforwardly extended to Tamil, given its non-syncretic, rich agreement paradigm that morphologically distinguishes 1SG, 1PL exclusive, 1PL inclusive, 2SG, 2PL, 3MSG, 3MPL, 3FSG, 3FPL, 3NSG, and 3NPL.

Crucially, furthermore, *any* other logically possible formulation that presumes Activity is also unviable for Tamil, given: (i) that ordinary raising is optional, (ii) that clausal finiteness is not a reliable predictor of case on the subject,

³Beyond Tamil, the *pro*-drop/hyperraising correlation is also weakened by languages where hyperraising is permitted even in contexts that disallow *pro*-drop, as Nunes (2008) argues for Brazilian Portuguese, and as Greeson (2024b), Greeson (to appear) argues for English. It appears then, that *pro*-drop is neither a necessary nor a sufficient condition for hyperraising.

given that both finite and non-finite subjects may bear case and, most importantly (iii) that a case-marked subject may undergo raising in this language.

Turning to (i), recall that raising out of a non-finite clause is optional in Tamil. A non-finite subject may remain in-situ, yielding default agreement on the superordinate verb (cf. (11), or may A-move to the superordinate clause feeding covarying φ -agreement on its clausemate verb (12). Under the classic assumption that raising is allowed only under Activity – concretely, the notion that the embedded subject is “active” for such movement on account of its not having received Case from non-finite T – this is entirely unexpected (and indeed, raising is not optional in English, whose properties shaped much of the theoretical canon). There is no evidence to suggest that the raised subject in the agreeing variant in (12) lacked case in its base-merged embedded subject position or that the in-situ embedded subject in the non-agreeing variant in (11) bears it. As we have seen, the two variants form a minimal pair, with the only difference between them being the nature of the agreement on the matrix verb. This, in turn, undermines the idea of Activity as a licenser of A-movement in Tamil.

Further evidence against the applicability of Activity in Tamil, at least as a reliable diagnostic for cross-clausal A-movement as a function of clausal finiteness comes from Sundaresan and McFadden (2009) who argue that the finiteness of T does not seem to correlate in any direct or obvious way with the possibility of case assignment to its subject. Evidence for this comes from a range of data showing that a non-finite subject may bear case, just like a finite subject can. This is even true in constructions like (15) (reformatted from Sundaresan and McFadden, 2009, Ex. 1b, 5) involving an embedded purposive adjunct clause, where there is really no obvious way to salvage a licensing account by positing an exceptional case licenser like the embedding verb (since adjuncts are, by definition, not selected by the verb):

- (15) Raman [Vasu puuri porikk-æ] maavi vaang-in-aan.
 Raman.NOM Vasu.NOM puuri.ACC fry-INF flour.ACC buy-PST-M.3SG
 ‘Raman bought flour for Vasu to fry puuris.’ (PURPOSIVE) ‘Raman bought flour while Vasu fried puuris.’ (TEMPORAL)

But perhaps the strongest evidence against the role of Activity in Tamil comes from the fact that an overtly case-marked non-finite subject can undergo subsequent A-movement, i.e. can raise. We show this using scope effects due to A-movement, starting with the observation that A-movement can feed binding, scope and Weak/Strong Crossover Effects at LF (Sauerland, 2003; van Urk, 2015). For instance, Sauerland (2003) shows that raising a quantified subject into a negated clause, as in (16), feeds an inverse scope reading between negation and the quantified subject, as in (16b), in addition to the surface scope reading in (16a) that was already present pre-movement:

- (16) [Every boy]_i didn't seem to his_i father [to be mature].
- Every boy was such that he didn't seem to his father to be mature.
($\checkmark \forall \gg \neg$)
 - It didn't seem to every boy's father that that boy was mature. ($\checkmark \neg \gg \forall$)

Given that ordinary raising of a nominative subject in Tamil feeds verbal agreement (cf. again (12)), we predict that any scope readings facilitated by raising should necessarily co-occur with changes in agreement in the raised-into clause and be distinguishable from scope readings available to the non-agreeing, in-situ minimal variant (cf. (11)). This prediction is fulfilled:

- (17) **In-situ, non-agreeing variant:**
 Ovvoṛ class-ləjʊm ɸenɖɨ pasəŋgə tuuŋ-gir-aa-maadiṛi
 every class-LOC two boys sleep-PRES-PRED-LIKE
 teri-ɖɨ-idi.
 seem-PST-3NSG
 A. $\times \exists \gg \forall$: Two boys were such that, in every class, they seemed asleep.
 B. $\checkmark \forall \gg \exists$: In every class, (some) two boys seemed asleep.
- (18) **Raised, agreeing variant:**
 Ovvoṛ class-ləjʊm ɸenɖɨ pasəŋgə tuuŋ-gir-aa-maadiṛi
 every class-LOC two boys sleep-PRES-PRED-LIKE
 teri-nɖɨ-aəŋgə.
 seem-PST-3MSG
 A. $\checkmark \exists \gg \forall$: Two boys were such that, in every class, they seemed asleep.
 B. $? \forall \gg \exists$: In every class, (some) two boys seemed asleep.

The non-agreeing variant in (17) is only compatible with the surface scope reading in B; the inverse scope reading in A is ruled out – consistent with the fact that the subject stays low. In contrast, the agreeing variant in (18) strongly favors the inverse scope A reading, again consistent with the subject having raised. While the surface scope reading in B is not impossible, suggesting that the subject may reconstruct at LF, it is indeed more marked, as indicated by the “?”.

Let us now see how this works when the embedded subject is overtly case-marked. Agreement can, unfortunately, not be used to diagnose A-movement of such a subject: clausal agreement only tracks a nominative argument, bearing default agreement when a nominative argument is absent, as we have noted; crucially furthermore, overt case-forms are always *non-nominative* in Tamil. As such, an overt case-marked subject will always trigger 3MSG agreement on the matrix verb, regardless of whether it has undergone raising into the matrix clause.

Fortunately, the Tamil scope data in (17)-(18) have shown that raising feeds scope relations at LF in Tamil, just like in English. We put this to the test below.

The embedded non-finite participial clause in (19) is built on the verb *puḍi* (‘like’) which takes a (quirky) dative subject and an accusative object; this participial clause is then embedded under our raising verb *teri* (‘seem’):

- (19) Ovvoṛi class-læjum reṇḍi paṣaṅgæ-ḷikki teacher-æ
 every class-LOC two boys-DAT teacher-ACC
 puḍi-ṭṭṭ-aa-maṭṭiri teri-nḍi-iḍi.
 like-PST-PRED-LIKE seem-PST-3NSG

A. $\checkmark \exists \gg \forall$: Two boys were such that, in every class, these boys seemed to like their teacher. B. $\checkmark \forall \gg \exists$: In every class, (some) two boys seemed to like their teacher.

The sentence in (19) is scopally ambiguous. The inverse scope reading in A is crucially available, just as in the raised, agreeing variant in (18); the surface scope reading is available, too, patterning with the non-agreeing, in-situ variant in (17). This is exactly what we expect if (19) string-identically expones two underlying structures: one where the dative subject stays in-situ in the embedded clause and another where, crucially for the current discussion, it has raised into the matrix clause.

Against this background, we can now confirm that Activity is not applicable in Tamil, thus cannot be used as an argument for or against hyperraising in this language. Such a conclusion is, in principle, compatible with two positions regarding the role of Activity in syntax: one which contends that Activity is not applicable in any language (Nevins, 2004b) argues and another which proposes that Activity is relevant only in a proper subset of languages, as proposed in Carstens (2011); Halpert (2019a) and others. However, regardless of which option we choose,⁴ the Tamil data makes clear that arguments for hyperraising based on the Activity Condition are not universally viable because they lack crosslinguistic predictive power.

4.2 Account based on CP intervention

The argument from CP intervention involves the idea that the (im)possibility of hyperraising in a given structure or a given language correlates with whether the clause hosting the subject is itself eligible to A-move or not. We will review this approach before showing that it, too, cannot be maintained in the face of relevant data from Tamil.

⁴There have been proposals in the literature arguing that the Activity Condition is problematic on other theoretical and empirical grounds (see e.g. the discussion in Sundaesan and Zeijlstra, *pear*). If we take these seriously, then the stronger option of abandoning the Activity Condition as a syntactic principle underlying A movement might be the way to go.

4.2.1 The argument from CP intervention

Halpert (2019a) and Halpert and Zeijlstra (2024) argue that opacity effects in syntax must be handled, not in terms of Activity or the PIC + BoIM, but in terms of Relativized Minimality. They point to case studies like Zulu (Halpert 2019b), where the possibility of A-movement out of a given XP seems to correlate with the status of XP as a potential EPP Goal. Infinitival TPs in Zulu, which may themselves occupy Spec TP (cf. (21)), thereby satisfying the EPP, *disallow* subject raising out of them (cf. (24)). By contrast, Zulu CPs, which *can* be hyperraised out of (cf. (23)), are *not* themselves possible occupiers of Spec TP/EPP satisfiers (cf. (20)). Halpert’s conclusion is that the possibility of (hyper)raising out of XP is mediated by whether XP itself intervenes for A-movement by creating an A-over-A configuration:

- (20) *_{[CP ukuthi w-a-thatha umhlala phansi] ku-ya-ngi-mangaza.}
_[CP that 1s-PST-take AUG.1sit down] 17s-YA-1SG.O-surprise]
 Intended: ‘That he retired surprises me.’ (*CP subject)
- (21) Uku-xova ujeqe ku-mnandi
 AUG.15-MAKE AUG.1steamed.bread 15s-nice
 “Making steamed bread is nice.” (TP subject)
- (22) ku-bonakala _[CP ukuthi uZinhle u-zo-xova ujeqe]
 17s-seem _[CP that AUG.1Zinhle 1s-FUT-make AUG.1bread]
 “It seems that Zinhle will make steamed bread.” (CP, no raising)
- (23) uZinhle u-/ku-bonakala _{[CP ukuthi uZinhle u-xova ujeqe].}
 AUG.1Zinhle 1s-/17s-seem _[CP that uZinhle 1s-make AUG.1bread]
 “Zinhle seems to be making steamed bread.” (Hyperraising)
- (24) *uZinhle u-bonakala _{[TP uZinhle uku-(zo)-xova ujeqe].}
 AUG.1Zinhle 1s-seem _[TP INF-(FUT)-make AUG.1bread]
 Intended: “It seems that Zinhle will make steamed bread.” (*TP raising)

4.2.2 Against CP intervention: the challenge from Tamil

We have seen that, per Halpert (2019a), Halpert and Zeijlstra (2024), an XP should block subject hyperraising out of it, just in case it is itself a possible candidate for movement to a matrix subject position). The relevant question for Tamil, then, is whether the embedded CP in (13b), repeated below in (25), competes for movement to the matrix subject position. It can be straightforwardly shown that this is not the case.

The language does permit gerundival clauses – even ones that involve the nominalization of a fully finite CP, as in (26). However, first, a raising verb in Tamil (e.g. *teri* ‘seem’) never selects a gerundival clause as a complement; and

second, the kind of finite CP selected by such a verb can never serve as a sentential subject in Tamil (27):

- (25) * Avan_i [$_{CP}$ ---_i sandoojam-aa $\text{iri-nd-aan-gir-aa-maadiri}$]
 he.NOM_i [$_{CP}$ ---_i happy-PRED be-ASP-3MSG-COMP-PRED-LIKE]
 teri-nd-aan.
 seem-PAST-3MSG.
 Lit: ‘He seemed like was happy.’ Intended: ‘He seemed to be happy.’
- (26) * $[_{CP}$ (Avan) sandoojamaa iri-nd-aan-gir-aedi] nallaadaa pootfifi.
 $[_{CP}$ he.NOM happy be-PST-3MSG-COMP-3MSG] good thing
 “That he was happy was fortunate.”
- (27) * $[_{CP}$ (Avan) sandoojamaa iri-nd-aan-gir-aa-maadiri]
 $[_{CP}$ he.NOM happy be-PST-3MSG-COMP-PRED-LIKE]
 nallaadaa pootfifi.
 good thing
 Intended: ‘That he was happy was fortunate.’

In sum, then, Minimality also fails to rule out hyperraising in Tamil: i.e. it predicts hyperraising to be possible in Tamil, contrary to fact.⁵

4.3 Summary of challenges posed by the Tamil data

We have argued in this section that explanations for the absence of hyperraising in terms of the Activity Condition or in terms of Minimality effects due to the CP itself serving as an intervener for subject extraction, do not work for Tamil. The Activity Condition does not underlie possibilities for syntactic movement in Tamil, thus cannot be invoked to explain the possibility (or absence) of hyperraising in this language. Clinching evidence for this comes from the fact that a case-marked subject can undergo subsequent raising-to-subject (cf. (19)); additional supporting evidence comes from the fact that classic raising is actually

⁵Notably, a Minimality-based account has also been independently argued to *undergenerate* hyperraising for a language like Brazilian Portuguese, where hyperraising is possible out of CPs which themselves are able to move to Spec,TP (Greson (2024a)):

- i. Esses lugares são certos que existem.
 these places are certain that exist
 “It is certain that these places exist.” Greson (2024a)
- ii. Que esses lugares existem é certo.
 that these places exist is certain
 “That these places exist is certain.” Greson (2024a)

optional in Tamil, with the optionality having seemingly nothing to do with the case on the moving subject and the fact that clausal finiteness is not a reliable predictor of subject case in this language, to begin with (Sundaresan and McFadden, 2009). The absence of hyperraising in Tamil also cannot be due to the finite embedded CP itself serving as an intervener for such movement since non-nominalized finite CPs can never serve as sentential subjects in this language.

Taken together, we take the discussion in this section to show that the predictive power of hyperraising accounts in terms of Activity or Relativized Minimality due to CP intervention are not crosslinguistically robust or reliable, even if they may be successful at explaining the prevalence of this phenomenon in one or more specific languages.

5 In support of accounts based on the PIC + GBoIM/WC

Another prominent line of analyses seeks to explain the distribution of hyperraising in terms of the PIC acting in conspiracy with the BoIM. Such proposals argue that hyperraising is allowed in a particular language or in a particular clausal environment just in case either the PIC or a generalized version of the Ban on Improper Movement (GBoIM), also called the Williams Cycle (WC) (Williams, 2003), may be circumvented in that language. In other words, such proposals argue either that the particular clause being hyperraised out of is not actually a phase – such that “hyperraising” is really just (ordinary) raising – or that subject movement to the matrix clause from its intermediate stopover point at the phase edge in Spec, CP exceptionally does not violate the BoIM.

Before we describe these analyses further, let us be clear about what we mean by the terms “PIC” and “GBoIM/WC”. We adopt the following definition of the Phase Impenetrability Condition (PIC):

- (28) *The Phase Impenetrability Condition:* In phase α with head H, the domain of H is not accessible to operations outside α , only H and its edge are accessible to such operations. (Chomsky, 2000, 108)

The ‘edge’ of a phase α is furthermore defined as the head and specifier of the head H of α . 28 thus has the consequence that a movement operation of a α -internal element to a α -external position can only proceed through the specifier or head of α . If CPs are phasal as is standardly assumed, this has the desired result of forcing subextraction from CPs to make an intermediate movement step through Spec,CP.

The Ban on Improper Movement, originally proposed in Chomsky (1973), has gone through different changes over time, as our empirical body of knowledge

of the world’s languages has grown. The classic version of the Ban on Improper Movement is as in (29).

- (29) Ban on Improper Movement: XP movement may not proceed from an $\bar{A}$ -position to an A-position.

Together, the BoIM and the PIC predict hyperraising to be impossible. In order to obey the PIC, a hyperraised DP must pass through Spec,CP on its way out of CP (assuming CP is phasal). But such a move would instead violate the BoIM under the classic assumption that CP is an ‘ $\bar{A}$ -position.’

The version of the BoIM in (29) is, however, no longer very tenable. First, the possibility of hybrid A/ $\bar{A}$ effects, observed in a language like Dinka (Van Urk, 2015), challenges the notion that the A vs. $\bar{A}$ distinction is a binary one, tied to binary differences in syntactic positions. Van Urk consequently argues in favor of a featural distinction between these properties, a stance that is now more or less widely accepted in the Minimalist syntax canon. Second, (29) is also not universally applicable, given direct evidence for A-movement proceeding through Spec,CP – a traditionally A-bar position – in some languages (Fong 2019).

Another approach to the ban on improper movement is Abels’ (2007) ‘UCOOL’, or Universal Constraint on Ordering of Operations in Language, subsequently adopted by Lohninger (2025) for hyperraising and similar A-movement dependencies that cross finite clause boundaries.

- (30) *Universal Constraint on Ordering of Operations in Language*
 Movement operations are hierarchically ordered into $\theta \ll A/\text{case} \ll Op$.
 No constituent may undergo movement of type α if it has undergone movement of type β , where α precedes β under UCOOL. Abels (2007)

UCOOL as an alternative to the classic BoIM is a step in the right direction, as it maintains principled restrictions on possible movement chains without under-generating long-distance A-movement. However, on its own, it does not predict ‘height effects’ of the sort we will demonstrate in this paper—namely, cases in which hyperraising subjects target a surprisingly high final landing site of matrix Spec,CP rather than Spec,TP in languages where Spec,TP is otherwise generally available as a subject position.

We will thus adopt a constraint that is sensitive to the relative heights of landing sites, namely Williams (1974, 2003, 2013)’s formulation of the GENERALIZED BAN ON IMPROPER MOVEMENT (GBoIM), also commonly known as the WILLIAMS CYCLE (WC), which is described below:⁶

⁶Note that we are not arguing against the existence of a constraint like UCOOL in natural language, but merely advocating for the necessity of the Williams Cycle, which could very well exist alongside UCOOL. This is because the Williams Cycle and UCOOL are not mutually exclusive under the definitions above, nor do they render each other redundant. It is, in principle, possible for

- (31) Generalized Ban on Improper Movement/Williams Cycle: Movement to [Spec, XP] cannot proceed from [Spec, YP] YP, where Y is higher than X in the functional sequence. Williams (2003)

5.1 Arguments from the PIC

We can identify two strands of analysis under this class: a phase-“unlocking” approach which proposes that the CP becomes phasal in the course of the syntactic derivation, and another where it is assumed not to be phasal to begin with.

A phase-unlocking approach posits that phases are not immutably opaque but, rather, may be ‘unlocked’ as a function of Agree. This, in turn, allows the embedded subject to hyperraise directly from Spec, TP without stopping over at the CP phase edge, thereby avoiding a violation of the BoIM.⁷ This is the approach argued for Cantonese and Vietnamese in Lee & Yip (2024). Lee & Yip show (a) that Vietnamese and Cantonese allow subject-to-subject hyperraising across a finite clause boundary and (b) that this hyperraising is only possible across attitude verbs that encode *indirect* perception; it is illicit over attitude verbs that encode direct perception. They take this to mean that the clausal complement of indirect perception verbs may be phasally unlocked while those of direct perception verbs may not.

- (32) Cantonese hyperraising asymmetry (Lee and Yip 2023):
- a. Hoenggong_i tenggong [_{CP} waa *tr*_i hou.
 Hong Kong hear [_{CP} COMP *tr* very dangerous].
 ‘Hong Kong is heard to be very dangerous.’ (indirect perception V)
 - b. *Hoenggong_i teng-dou [_{CP} waa *tr*_i hou ngaihim].
 Hong Kong hear-ACCOMP [_{CP} COMP *tr* very dangerous].

a derivation to obey the Williams Cycle but violate UCOOL—imagine, for instance, a derivation in which Williams Cycle-compliant *wh*-movement (e.g. movement of a *wh*-object from object position to matrix Spec,CP) precedes a step of Williams Cycle-compliant A-movement (e.g. ‘further raising’ of the *wh*-DP to Spec,CP of the next clause up, triggered by a ϕ -probe on this C head). Furthermore, the inverse is also possible, i.e. a derivation that obeys UCOOL but violates the Williams Cycle—for instance, a plausible raising-to-object derivation of a sentence like *Who was expected to win?* obeys UCOOL (A-movement of the infinitival subject to matrix object position *precedes wh*-movement), but would violate the Williams Cycle under a potential analysis involving A-movement from embedded Spec,TP to matrix ν P, given that T dominates ν in the functional sequence (see 8 for discussion of so-called “raising-to-object” and ways to analyze it without violating the Williams Cycle). While we will not address the question of whether UCOOL needs to exist alongside the Williams Cycle any further, we leave this possibility open.

⁷Of course, to make this work, such approaches additionally need to assume that ν P is not a phase. Otherwise, the embedded subject would first need to stop over at the edge of matrix ν P, and would thus still violate the BoIM. We return to the issue of ν P phasality in Section 8.

Intended: ‘Hong Kong is heard to be very dangerous.’ (direct perception V)

Other approaches in this vein maintain a strong interpretation of the PIC but claim that it does not apply to the particular embedded clauses that allow hyper-raising because these are (exceptionally) non-phasal. This appears to be the case for Brazilian Portuguese, where it has been independently argued that particular properties of T in the language make the class of hyperraising-permitting CPs non-phasal or ‘weakly’ phasal Nunes (2008). This means, concretely, that the hyperraising subject does not make an intermediate stopover at Spec, CP before it moves up to its final landing site. Non-phasality has also been invoked for instances of hyperraising reported in languages where finite embedded clauses lack a CP layer altogether (e.g. hyperraising out of TP in Moro, as in Jenks 2025).

5.2 Arguments from the WC

As a logical alternative, one could assume that the CP in question is indeed phasal and focus on circumventing the Ban on Improper Movement, instead. Fong (2019) pursues this strategy for hyperraising in Mongolian. She argues that Mongolian allows hyperraising-to-object with intermediate movement through Spec,CP, because Spec,CP is simply not an $\bar{A}$ -position in Mongolian, thus does not create an ‘improper’ A-movement chain.

- (33) Bat chang-aar [_{CP} nokhoi(-g) gaikhal-tai gej] khel-sen.
 Bat loud-INSTR [_{CP} dog(-ACC) wonder-with COMP] say-PST
 “Bat said loudly that dogs are wonderful.” (No HR)
- (34) Bat nokhoi-g chang-aar [_{CP} ~~nokhoi-g~~ gaikhal-tai gej] khel-sen
 Bat dog-ACC loud-INST [_{CP} ~~dog-ACC~~ wonder-with COMP]
 “Bat said loudly that dogs are wonderful.” (HR to object)

Fong provides further evidence from binding and word order to show that these hyperraising examples crucially involve intermediate movement through the embedded Spec,CP. She concludes, therefore, that the Ban on Improper Movement cannot be universal since, at a minimum, it cannot hold for Mongolian under her analysis.

For the purposes of the rest of this paper, it should be noted that while Fong’s finding is an important one, it nevertheless does not ultimately shed much light on the underlying nature of the Ban on Improper Movement itself, how it should be parametrized, or whether it should even exist at all. It is for this reason that in this section we have turned to refined formulations of the Ban on Improper Movement, as in (31), that attempt to capture variation with respect to

its crosslinguistic effects without merely stipulating a constraint that varies in its applicability. As noted earlier, Lohninger (2025) develops an analysis of hyperraising and other hybrid A-dependencies in terms of the UCOOL constraint in (6) proposed by Abels (2007). The findings of this paper, while not necessarily incompatible with UCOOL (cf. Fn. 6), will nevertheless be seen to argue in favor of a height-based formulation of the Williams Cycle like that in (31) acting either instead of, or in tandem with, UCOOL.

5.3 Independent support for the PIC + WC approach

We will now present evidence from a selection of unrelated languages to show that the landing position of the hyperraised subject is higher than that occupied by canonical clausal subjects (which we take to be Spec, TP); these subjects, instead, seem to occupy a position that is at least as high as Spec, CP. We then proceed to show that, in languages where the finite CP containing the base-merged subject has been argued not to be phasal, the final landing site of the hyperraised subject need not be as high.

Taken together, these patterns to argue in favor of the WC acting in conspiracy with the PIC in regulating possibilities for A movement in a given language. Concretely, they show that the structural height of the hyperraised subject is entirely non-trivial in determining possibilities for hyperraising in a given language, as predicted by the WC, and that the precise height of the landing site is, in turn, determined by whether the subject makes an intermediate stopover at Spec, CP or not.

5.3.1 Default agreement due to intervening expletive in Spec, TP

In many Romance languages (e.g. Catalan, European Portuguese, Galician, and Spanish, Fernández-Salgueiro (2005)), hyperraising takes the form of so-called ‘further-raising’, in which the moved subject triggers default agreement on the raising verb. This contrasts with ordinary raising out of infinitivals, and with non-raised subjects, which obligatorily trigger φ -agreement (37–38).

- (35) Vosotros puede que tengáis razón.
 2PL.NOM can.3SG that have-2PL.SUBJ reason
 ‘It might be that you guys are right.’ Ausín and Depiante (2023)
- (36) *Vosotros podéis que tengáis razón.
 2PL.NOM can-2PL that have-2PL.SUBJ reason.
 Intended: “It might be that you guys are right.” Ausín and Depiante (2023)

- (37) Vosotros podéis tener razón.
 2PL.NOM can-2PL have.INF reason
 ‘You guys could be right.’ (Ordinary raising)
- (38) Vosotros tenéis razón.
 2PL.NOM have-2PL reason
 ‘You guys are right.’ (Non-raised subject)

By itself, the fact that (35) fails to trigger φ -agreement suggests that we are dealing with an A-position other than the canonical φ -agreeing subject position in the language (i.e. Spec,TP). Ausín and Depiante (2023) suggest that φ -agreement with the preverbal argument *Juan y Pedro* is blocked by the presence of a 3SG-bearing (i.e. default) *pro_{expl}* in Spec,TP. This, in turn, suggests that *Juan y Pedro* is located in a higher position, namely in matrix Spec,CP. Despite this unusually high landing site for raising/A-movement, we can apply the diagnostics from Fernández-Salgueiro (2005) to show that this dependency behaves like A-movement and unlike strictly $\bar{A}$ -topicalization in Spanish. First, this construction preserves idioms:

- (39) Mala hierba puede que nunca muera.
 bad herb can.3SG that never dies.SUBJ
 ‘It might be that evil is hard to defeat.’

Another diagnostic from Fernández-Salgueiro (2005) concerns *ad sensum* agreement. While $\bar{A}$ -displaced hanging topics in Spanish are compatible with *ad sensum* agreement on the embedded verb (40), the hypothesized hyperraised argument over *puede que* is not.

- (40) El equipo, sé que __ están atrasados. ($\bar{A}$ topicalization)
 The.SG team know.1SG that __ be-3PL late.PL
 ‘The team, I know that they’re running late.’ (XX, p.c.)
- (41) El equipo puede que { esté / *estén } atrasados.
 the team can.3SG that { be-3SG.SUBJ / be-3PL.SUBJ } late.PL.
 (No prosodic break)

‘It might be that the team is running late.’ (XX, p.c.)

Finally, Fernández-Salgueiro (2005) points to intervention effects that are typical of A-movement, such as the degradation of an intervening experiencer over *parece* (‘seems’).⁸

⁸Up to now, we have been using *puede* ‘can’ instead of *parece* ‘seem’ to illustrate hyperraising in Spanish, because *parecer* is often ambiguous between an athematic raising verb like English

- (42) *Juan y Pedro me parece que son listos.
 John and Pedro 1SG.DAT seem.3SG that be-3PL clever.
 (No prosodic break)

Intended “It seems to me that Juan and Pedro are clever.” Pires and Nediger (2018)

The lack of *ad sensum* agreement, idiom preservation, and intervention facts suggest that we are dealing with A-movement (see Fernández-Salgueiro (2005) for island data and other evidence for movement in general). What’s striking about this case of A-movement, though, is that it does not trigger ϕ -agreement. We attribute this lack of ϕ -agreement to a high landing site above Spec,TP, the canonical position for ϕ -agreeing subjects. Such an analysis is supported by the fact that this type of hyperraising is possible over impersonal *se* constructions with an intervening *se* subject clitic, argued to reside in Spec,TP (Raposo and Uriagereka 1996). The following example of hyperraising over *se* comes from (Fernández-Salgueiro (2005))⁹

- (43) Los romanos se decía que eran muy listos.
 the Romans SE said.3SG that were-3PL very smart
 “It was said that the Romans were very smart.”

So far, we have solid evidence that Spanish has a type of hyperraising, and this hyperraising targets a position above Spec,TP, i.e. Spec,CP or higher. This is not a lone fact about Spanish, either. Similar facts to the Spanish data just described occur in Tiriki (Johnson and Diercks (2024)), which also boasts a hyper-raising construction in which the hyperraised subject fails to trigger φ -agreement on the matrix verb.

- (44) Va-ana *pro*_{EVIDENCE} ka-loloekh-a khuli va-tukh-i.
 2-child *pro*_{EVIDENCE} 6SM-seem-FV that 2SM-arrive-FV.
 “The children seem to have arrived.”

seem and a visual perception predicate like English *looks like* which does assign a θ -role to its subject. *Puede que* (‘It might be that . . .’), however, is unambiguously athematic. Unlike *parece*, though, *puede* is incompatible with an experiencer argument, so we have to use *parece* to illustrate intervention effects.

⁹This raises a separate question of why dative experiencers do intervene, as seen in (42), while *se* does not. However, the question of *se*’s status of an intervener is a larger one, and also applies to ordinary raising constructions, e.g.:

- (1) El ajenjo se creía ser una planta venenosa.
 the wormwood SE thought.3SG be.INF a plant poisonous
 “Wormwood was thought to be a poisonous plant.” (web)

Unlike in Spanish, where agreement with an intervening subject is identical to ‘default’ (3sg) agreement, the 6sm agreement on the matrix verb in Tiriki is a special kind of ‘expletive’ agreement that corresponds semantically to a source of evidence. Accordingly, Johnson and Diercks (2024) propose that there is an intervening evidential *pro* merged between the raised subject and the matrix verb.

In recent work, Greeson (2024b) argues – based on a range of data culled from various sources on the internet, and confirmed with native-speaker elicitation – that certain colloquial varieties of English actually permit hyperraising. This seems to be attested in sentences like (45), with Greeson arguing that such constructions constitute a bona fide case of hyperraising on the basis of weak crossover, subject/object asymmetries, anti-reconstruction effects, and case continuity effects (the reader is referred to Greeson (2024b) for these diagnostics.)

- (45) Juan and Pedro it seems ~~Juan and Pedro~~ are happy.

Per Greeson, the evidence for a high subject position in English is arguably even stronger, since the equivalent of the hypothesized *pro_{expl}/pro_{evidence}* in Spanish & Tiriki must be overtly spelled out in English since it doesn’t allow pro-drop – note that the variant without the overt expletive is judged to be ungrammatical by speakers of this dialect:

- (46) *Juan and Pedro seems ~~Juan and Pedro~~ are happy.

Crucially, furthermore, Greeson observes that, just like in Spanish and Tiriki, the A-moved subject *Juan and Pedro* also fails to trigger φ -agreement on the matrix verb *seems* – the variant in (47) with covarying plural agreement on *seem* is strictly ungrammatical:

- (47) *Juan and Pedro seem ~~Juan and Pedro~~ are happy.

The English data, all of which include an intervening expletive *it* between the raised DP and the matrix verb (which fails to act as an intervener, much like Spanish *se*). This provides further support for a landing site in Spec,CP similar to what we saw in Spanish and Tiriki.

The existence of hyperraising to Spec,CP is itself a strong argument in favor of something like the Williams Cycle. If height doesn’t matter, then we have no reason to predict that hyperraising should target a position higher than the canonical subject position, i.e. Spec,TP. The fact that it does is surprising, but makes sense considering the Williams Cycle: assuming successive cyclic movement through embedded Spec,CP, the next landing site for a hyperraised argument must be at least as high as matrix CP.

5.3.2 Independent evidence for a high A position

More indirect supporting evidence comes from data showing that at least some hyperraising languages have independent recourse to a high subject position. This is true for Spanish and the relevant colloquial varieties of English which manifest hyperraising (Fernández-Salgueiro 2005, Greeson 2024b). These languages allow embedded subjects to move to a high position in the matrix clause, even outside of ordinary hyperraising constructions.

(48) He I think is happy.

(49) Él (yo) cre-o que está content-o.
3SG.NOM (1SG.NOM think-1.SG is.3SG content-MASC.
“He I think is happy.”

At first glance, it looks like the sentences in (48)–(49) simply instantiate $\bar{A}$ -topicalization. But such sentences obey standard diagnostics for A, not $\bar{A}$, movement. For instance, they obviate weak crossover even with universally quantified DPs (ruling out the possibility that we are dealing with so-called “weakest” crossover, cf. Lasnik and Stowell (1991).

(50) Every dog_i(,) its_i owner think is the cutest one in the world.

(51) Todos los perritos_i(,) sus_i dueños creen que son muy tiernos. all the
puppies their owners think that are very tender “All dogs_i their_i owners
think are very cute.” (Spanish)

Such data provide independent evidence that a higher-than-usual A position is at least available in such languages, which can then serve as a landing site for a hyperraised subject.

5.3.3 Hyperraised subjects out of non-phasal CPs land lower

While we have argued that hyperraising targets a high thematic A-position in order to comply with the Williams Cycle in some languages, it is not the case that *every* case of hyperraising crosslinguistically must necessarily target a landing site at least as high as Spec,CP in order to comply with the Williams Cycle. Recall that the high landing site requirement follows from a *conspiracy* of the Williams Cycle/Generalized BoIM and the PIC –the latter forces movement to proceed through embedded Spec,CP, which in turn forces the final landing site to be as high as matrix Spec,CP.

In the languages we have discussed above, finite CPs have crucially been shown to constitute phases. For Spanish, Torrego (1983) provides evidence from interactions between complementizer spellout and *wh*-extraction that strongly

suggest subextraction from embedded CPs obligatorily stops over in the embedded Spec,CP before proceeding to the matrix clause. For English, evidence for intermediate movement abounds in the literature: e.g. realization of intermediate *wh* copies in Spec,CP by children (Liter et al 2022), or quantifier stranding possibilities in certain varieties of English (McCloskey 2000). Finally, *wh*-islands, traditionally understood as a reflex of CP-phasehood, have been robustly observed in Romance (Bonan 2021), English (Ross 1967b), and Great Lakes Bantu (Wasike 2006) languages of which Tariki is a member.

However, if it can be shown that the PIC does *not* apply to hyperraising in a given language, removing the need for an intermediate Spec,CP landing site, then a Williams Cycle-compliant Spec,TP-to-Spec,TP move must indeed be possible.¹⁰ We have shown that Spanish, Tiriki and certain varieties of English instantiate the latter option. This leaves open the possibility that other languages may allow hyperraising, not because they have available an exceptionally high subject position, but because the clause that is being hyperraised out of is exceptionally non-phasal.

A good candidate for such a language is Brazilian Portuguese. Brazilian Portuguese has been shown to have hyperraising (Nunes (2008)), and has also been argued to differ from other Romance languages, in which CPs are strong phases, in (at least optionally) realizing non-phasal CPs. Nunes (2022) argues more generally that Brazilian Portuguese displays a cluster of related properties that together suggest Brazilian Portuguese lacks strong phases altogether, a property that may be attributed to BP's history of sustained contact with other languages and high numbers of L2 speakers in various periods of its history. If we follow Nunes' analysis of non-phasal CPs in Brazilian Portuguese, then we correctly predict that a hyperraised subject in BP, A-moving from embedded Spec, TP, may target a position as low as Spec,TP in the higher clause without violating the WC. This prediction is borne out: as weak pronouns like *cê* and the phonologically reduced form of *você* (you.SG) can be hyperraised subjects in Brazilian Portuguese despite being unable to occupy a higher 'outer subject' A-position:

- (52) *Cê* parece que tá doente.
 you.weak seem that are sick
 'It seems that you are sick.'
- (53) **Cê* eu acho que tá doente.
 you.weak I think that are sick
 Intended: 'I think that you are sick'.

¹⁰ Arguably, then, this is not, strictly speaking, a case of *hyperraising*, but just ordinary raising. Nevertheless, we will notionally retain the term 'hyperraising' for such cases for now.

5.4 Theoretical implications

The evidence presented here strongly suggests that, in at least some languages that allow hyperraising, the hyperraised subject moves to a non-canonically high subject position, above Spec, TP – e.g. in Spec, CP. Van Urk (2015)’s treatise presented compelling evidence from hybrid A/ $\bar{A}$ effects in Dinka to argue that the A vs. $\bar{A}$ distinction is neither binary nor neatly bifurcated across syntactic positions. Since then, there has been a surge of interest in and research into other languages around the world which show similar hybrid effects (Lohninger et al. 2022, Lohninger 2023, Lohninger 2025, 2025 2025) The evidence presented here, showing that Spec, CP – once assumed to be a strictly $\bar{A}$ position – can actually also manifest A properties in Spanish, Tiriki and varieties of English should, thus, no longer surprise us. At the same time, we have suggested that there is a non-trivial correlation between the availability of such hybrid effects and the possibility of hyperraising in some languages, in line with the A/ $\bar{A}$ analysis of hyperraising given by Lohninger et al. (2022), Lohninger and Yip (2023), and Lohninger (2025).

Far from being surprising, such patterns are precisely what we expect under the Williams Cycle, as formulated in (31), working in conjunction with the PIC, as defined in (28): canonical infinitival raising can proceed from Spec,TP to Spec,TP without issue, but a hyperraising derivation subject to the PIC must target a matrix landing site at least as high as Spec,CP in order to avoid a Williams Cycle violation. Such data thus serve to support the idea of the WC as a core underlying principle of syntax, working in conjunction with a locality principle like the PIC.¹¹

Given, too, that the WC cannot regulate hyperraising on its own but must do so in conjunction with the PIC, we also predict another type of language to be possible, namely one that lacks a high A position but nevertheless allows hyperraising because the clause that the subject moves out of is not a phase, and thus is not subject to the PIC. We have shown that Brazilian Portuguese seems to be just such a language, supporting the proposal in Nunes (2008). On the strength of the data presented in this section, and in the absence of counter-evidence to this claim, we will now thus adopt the strong hypothesis in (54):

- (54) Necessary input condition for a hyperraising language: Hyperraising(-to-subject) in some language L is possible only if long subject movement can obtain without violating the PIC or the WC (or both), in L .

Allowing the WC to apply in tandem with the PIC in this way also has

¹¹How the WC is actually formally implemented in a derivational grammar is a deeper question, which lies beyond the scope of the current paper. See Meadows (2024), Poole (2023), Egressy (2023) on this question.

implications for how the WC itself is formulated. Crucially, in order for PIC-circumventing hyperraising to be allowed under the Williams Cycle (as we argue is the case in Brazilian Portuguese), the definition of the WC must be exactly as it appears in Williams (2003) as we have been assuming, and not the stronger version of the WC that has been advocated in works like Poole (2023), Meadows (2024), and Egressy (2025).

Note, incidentally, that a stronger version of the Williams Cycle bans not only movement *from* a relatively higher position to a relatively lower position in the functional sequence, but also movement *across* a relatively higher position to a relatively lower position in the functional sequence:

- (55) Generalized Ban on Improper Movement/Williams Cycle (Strong version, rejected here): Movement to [Spec, XP] cannot proceed from **or across** [Spec, YP] YP, where Y is higher than X in the functional sequence. Williams (2003)

The formulation of the WC given in (55) would not allow for crosslinguistic variation with respect to hyperraising's landing site. Even in a PIC-circumventing language like Brazilian Portuguese (see Nunes 2008), the Williams Cycle would be violated by a move from embedded Spec,TP to matrix Spec,TP even without an intermediate step in Spec,CP. This is because (55) bans movement from Spec,TP to Spec,TP *across* a CP boundary. Given that (a) there is positive evidence for hyperraised subjects landing in Spec,TP in Brazilian Portuguese, and (b) Brazilian Portuguese has been independently argued to have defective CP phases, we favor the original, slightly weaker formulation of the Williams Cycle given in Williams (1974) and Williams (2003).

6 PIC + WC at work in Tamil

If we are correct in our hypothesis in (54), we expect that the PIC, working in conjunction with the WC, might finally give us a way to understand the absence of hyperraising in Tamil. In this section, we will show that this prediction is fulfilled. Concretely, we present evidence here showing that hyperraising is banned in Tamil, not because the finite CP hosting the subject candidate for hyperraising is non-phasal, as has been argued for Brazilian Portuguese in Nunes (2008), but because the subject cannot move out of the edge of its CP phase to its landing position in the higher clause without incurring a violation of the WC. To this end, we show that Tamil – unlike Spanish, Tiriki and the varieties of English discussed above – does not have a recourse to a subject position which is higher than its intermediate stopover position in Spec, CP.

6.1 Finite CPs are phasal in Tamil

We show below that finite CPs are base-generated as phases in Tamil and, crucially, that they remain phasal (i.e. do not undergo phase unlocking) throughout the syntactic derivation.

6.1.1 Against base-generated non-phasality

Evidence that finite CPs start the derivation as phases comes from long *wh*-movement in Tamil. Long *wh*-movement can, in certain dialects, show reflexes of intermediate movement at the clausal phase-edge, e.g. Spec, CP. For instance, in (56) below, adapted from Malhotra and Chandra (2008)), a copy of the *wh*-word *jennæ* is pronounced in the intermediate Spec,CP position:

- (56) [_{CP} Seetha jennæ_i namb-in-aal] [_{CP} Raman jennæ_i
 Seetha what believe-PST-3FSG Raman what
 nene-tʃtʃ-aan [_{CP} Sri jaar-æ_i paa-tt-aan-nni]]?
 think-PST-3MSG [Sri who-ACC see-PST-3MSG-COMP]
 Lit: ‘What did Seetha believe what Raman thought who Sri saw?’ In-
 tended: ‘Who did Seetha believe that Raman thought that Sri saw?’

It should be noted that reflexes of intermediate movement at the finite CP edge do not automatically force the conclusion that finite CPs are phasal (cf. alternative explanations proffered for this in Halpert and Zeijlstra, 2024, in terms of CP intervention). At the same time, given that we have *independently* shown that a Minimality-based account of the absence of hyperraising is unviable in Tamil (cf. §4.2.2) – it is difficult at this time to interpret the data in (56) as anything other than in support of the phasal status of finite CPs in Tamil.

6.1.2 Against derivational non-phasality (phase-unlocking)

A phase-unlocking account, as in Lee and Yip (2023), also overgenerates the possibility of hyperraising in Tamil. Lee and Yip show that the set of attitude predicates in Vietnamese and Cantonese that allow and disallow hyperraising across them are neatly divided according to evidentiality/directness of perception. Attitude predicates that encode direct sensory perception disallow hyperraising, while attitude predicates that encode *indirect* perception allow it. To account for this, the authors propose that evidentiality is syntactically encoded: concretely, they posit that an indirect perception verb in these languages hosts an uninterpretable [*uEV_{indirect}*] feature which probes and Agrees with its CP complement bearing the interpretable counterpart of this feature. This instance of Agree suffices to ‘unlock’ (Rackowski and Richards, 2005) the otherwise opaque

phase for further operations, including hyperraising. Lee and Yip (2023) go on to suggest that different types of evidentiality features may be leveraged in different languages to mediate hyperraising, e.g. proposing that Spanish is a language that deploys a *direct* evidentiality feature to unlock a complement CP for hyperraising-to-object (Herbeck (2020)).

Greeson (2024b) argues against Lee & Yip’s account on the grounds that indirect perception predicates permit A-movement to their specifiers because their subjects are *athematic*, unlike subjects of direct perception predicates. Thus, the θ -criterion rules out movement from an embedded thematic position to the subject position of a direct perception predicate but not the subject position of an indirect perception predicates. Greeson further notes that the asymmetry between indirect & direct perception predicates asymmetry goes beyond hyperraising and also appears to regulate ordinary raising out of infinitival TPs in English, calling into question the relevance of ‘phase unlocking’ altogether. This suggests that a phase unlocking account might not be the correct one, to begin with. Here, we will make the weaker point that such an approach doesn’t work in Tamil, which in turn renders it unviable as a crosslinguistically robust account of hyperraising.

Tamil morphologically encodes different evidentiality distinctions such as hearsay and indirect inference and also marks mirativity (Bashir et al. (2006)). This makes it fairly straightforward to test Lee & Yip’s proposal by seeing whether an evidentially marked clause in Tamil exceptionally allows hyperraising through putative phase unlocking. The results show very clearly, however, that hyperraising remains impossible in Tamil regardless of the flavor of evidential marked on the matrix verb, be it hearsay (57), indirect evidence (58), or mirativity (59).¹²:

- (57) * Avan_i [$_{CP}$ ---_i $\text{tuuŋ-gir-aan-gir-aa-maadiri}$]
 he.NOM_i [$_{CP}$ ---_i $\text{sleep-ASP-3MSG-COMP-PRED-LIKE}$]
 teri-nḁ-aan-aam .
 seem-PAST-3MSG-EVID_{hearsay}
 Intended (hearsay): ‘He apparently seemed like was sleeping.’
- (58) * Avan_i [$_{CP}$ ---_i $\text{tuuŋ-gir-aan-gir-aa-maadiri}$]
 he.NOM_i [$_{CP}$ ---_i $\text{sleep-ASP-3MSG-COMP-PRED-LIKE}$]
 $\text{teri-nḁ-irikkæ-ṇum}$.
 seem-PAST-have been-must
 Intended: ‘He must have seemed like was sleeping.’

¹²Note that in all the examples below, the matrix verb appears with covarying agreement that matches the φ -features of the overt subject: as we have established, this is the only kind of construction that would hypothetically involve hyperraising. The minimal variant with default agreement on the matrix verb involves a structure where the embedded subject stays in situ. As is to be expected, this variant is indeed grammatical in the evidential example given here.

- (59) **Avan_i* [_{CP} _i *tuuŋ-gir-aan-gir-aa-maadiri*]
 he.NOM_i [_{CP} _i *sleep-ASP-3MSG-COMP-PRED-LIKE*]
teri-ndɔ̌-aan-ee!
 seem-PAST-3MSG-MIR
 Intended: ‘He seemed like was sleeping!’

These data show that syntactic encoding of evidentiality cannot be a sufficient condition for licensing hyperraising crosslinguistically. Indeed, if Greeson (2024b) is correct, it may not be a necessary condition, either.

6.2 On the absence of a high subject position in Tamil

Our formulation of the GBoIM/WC in (31) has the consequence that a subject cannot make the standard PIC-compliant move from embedded Spec, CP to matrix Spec,TP, since TP is lower than CP in the functional sequence. Since Tamil is a language we have shown is PIC-compliant for finite clauses, a plausible reason for why it lacks hyperraising could be that there is no landing site for HR subjects that obeys the WC, i.e. is sufficiently high (e.g. at least as high as Spec,CP).

In Section §5.3, we presented evidence to argue that the possibility of hyperraising correlates with the availability of a higher-than-usual A position, at least in some languages: namely, (i) default agreement on the hyperraising verb due to an intervening expletive subject in Spec, TP and (ii) word-order facts in non-hyperraising constructions. Below, we will walk through these diagnostics for Tamil and show that each of them fails.

6.2.1 Impossibility of default agreement

In Section 3.3, we showed that when a raising verb *teri* (‘seem’) take a finite CP complement, it must bear 3NSG agreement and cannot bear agreement that tracks the φ -features of the overt subject – see the minimal pair repeated below:

- (60) Absence of hyperraising out of finite CP:
- a. [_{CP} *Avan_i* *sandooŋam-aa* *iri-ndɔ̌-aan-gir-aa-maadiri*]
 [_{CP} *he.NOM_i* *happy-PRED* *be-ASP-3MSG-COMP-PRED-LIKE*]
teri-ndɔ̌-adi.
 seem-PAST-3NSG.
 ‘It seemed like he is going to be happy.’
- b. **Avan_i* [_{CP} _i *sandooŋam-aa* *iri-ndɔ̌-aan-gir-aa-maadiri*]
he.NOM_i [_{CP} _i *happy-PRED* *be-ASP-3MSG-COMP-PRED-LIKE*]
teri-ndɔ̌-aan.
 seem-PAST-3MSG.

Lit: ‘He seemed like was happy.’ Intended: ‘Avan seemed to be happy.’

In analogy with classic raising patterns in Tamil, where the agreeing variant bears the hallmarks of genuine raising while, in its non-agreeing counterpart, the subject remains in-situ, we proposed that the impossibility of covaryinbg agreement in (60b) entails the impossibility of hyperraising.

But we have seen in Section 5 that hyperraising constructions in Spanish, Tiriki and Colloquial English necessarily show default agreement on the matrix verb (cf. the example repeated below for Spanish):

- (61) Juan y Pedro parece que son muy listos.
 Juan and Pedro seem.3SG that are very intelligent
 Lit: ‘Juan and Pedro seem that are very intelligent.’ Intended: ‘It seems that Juan and Pedro are very intelligent.’ (Hyperraising)

We argued there that the impossibility of plural agreement triggered by the hyperraised subject in (61) is due to an intervening null expletive subject in Spec, TP which, being closer to T triggers default agreement on it instead. Could a similar argument be made for Tamil? In other words, can we independently confirm that the non-agreeing variant in (60a) involves the in-situ A structure in (62) and not the hyperraised B structure in (63) below?:

- (62) *pro*.DAT [_{CP_{fin}} Avan sandoofam-aa iri-nd-aan-gir-aa-maadiri] *teri-nd-id*.
pro.DAT [_{CP_{fin}} He seemed like was happy] (Structure A: in-situ subject)
- (63) *Avan*_i [_{CP_{fin}} *—*_i sandoofam-aa iri-nd-aan-gir-aa-maadiri] *teri-nd-id*.
*He*_i [_{CP_{fin}} *—*_i seemed like was happy]. (Structure B: non-agreeing hyperraising)

It appears that we can. Strong evidence against Structure B comes from restrictions on cross-clausal scrambling. Clausemate arguments in Tamil can be locally scrambled relative to one another (64) but an argument cannot be scrambled across another in a higher clause (65):

- (64) ✓ Local scrambling:
 a. Ena-kki muun*i* ko*ḷ*endæ-*ṇ*gæ iri-kk-aan*ḡ*æ.
 me-DAT three kid-PL be-PRS-3.PL
 ‘I have three kids.’
 b. Mu*ṇ*i ko*ḷ*endæ-*ṇ*gæ*i* enakki *—*_i iri-kk-aan*ḡ*æ.
 three kid-PL me-DAT *—*_i be-PRS-3.PL
 ‘Three kids, I have.’
- (65) ✗ Non-local scrambling:

- a. Naan [nii tuuŋg-in-æ-nni] nene-tʃʃ-een.
 I.NOM you.NOM sleep-PST-2SG-COMP think-PST-1SG
 ‘I thought you slept.’
- b. *Nii_i naan [____i tuuŋg-in-æ-nni] nene-tʃʃ-een.
 you.NOM I.NOM ____i sleep-PST-2SG-COMP think-PST-1SG
 Intended: ‘You, I thought slept.’

Turning now to our raising verb *teri-* (‘seem’), we note first that it takes a dative experiencer subject, which may be pro-dropped, as shown in (66):

- (66) (En-ækki) appaḍi teri-nḍ-iḍi.
 me-DAT so seem-PST-3NSG
 ‘It seemed so (to me).’

A dative subject may also be overtly represented in the non-agreeing sentence in (13a). Crucially, this subject must precede *avan* (‘he’), as in (67), and cannot follow it, as in (68):¹³

- (67) [En-ækki avan sandooḍam-aa iri-nḍ-aaṇ-gir-aa-maadiri]
 me-DAT he.NOM happy-PRED be-ASP-3MSG-COMP-PRED-LIKE]
 teri-nḍ-iḍi.
 seem-PAST-3NSG.
 ‘It seemed to me like he was happy.’
- (68) *[Avan en-ækki sandooḍam-aa iri-nḍ-aaṇ-gir-aa-maadiri]
 he.NOM me-DAT happy-PRED be-ASP-3MSG-COMP-PRED-LIKE]
 teri-nḍ-iḍi.
 seem-PAST-3NSG.
 ≈ ‘It seemed to me like he was happy.’

This, in turn, supports the idea that *avan* (‘he’) really is in-situ in embedded subject position; (68) is then predicted to be bad, given that it involves non-local scrambling, which is disallowed elsewhere.

Further evidence against Structure B comes from the fact that the subject *avan* cannot be stranded by a CP-substituting expression (69) (‘like-that’) – compare with (66) above:

¹³Again, note the contrast with Spanish, where non-agreeing hyperraised subjects (*cf.* Fernández-Salgueiro (2005)) may precede a dative experiencer:

- i. Esto me parece [_{CP} que ~~esto~~ va a ser un problema].
 this 1SG.DAT seems [that ~~this~~ goes to be-INF a problem]
 ‘It seems to me that this is going to be a problem.’

- (69) *En-ækki avan appaḍi teri-ndḡ-iḍi.
 me-DAT he.NOM so seem-PST-3NSG
 Intended: ‘He seemed so to me.’

We take this cluster of facts to show conclusively that it is not the case that hyperraising obtains with default agreement being forced on the verb due to an intervening null expletive. Rather, hyperraising is ruled out in Tamil altogether.

6.2.2 Impossibility of embedded subject displacement

In Section 5.3, we presented evidence suggesting that hyperraised subjects in Spanish and some colloquial varieties of English occupy a higher surface position than Spec, TP (cf. Exx. (48)-(49)). We also saw that movement to this position bears all the hallmarks of A-, not A-bar, movement, e.g. allowing obviation of WCO.

We can again show that such a possibility is ruled out in Tamil. Even though Tamil allows local scrambling elsewhere (Sarma 2003), subject A-movement to a position above matrix Spec,TP is impossible. The sentence in (70) is thus ungrammatical under the intended reading involving coreference between *Hasan* and *avan* (‘he’).

- (70) (*Hasan_i) avanoodḡæ_i amma [Hasan soogam-aa iru-ndḡ-aan-nni]
 (Hasan) his mom [Hasan sad-PRED be-PST-3MSG-COMP]
 nene-tḡḡ-aa].
 think-PST-3SGF.
 Intended: “Hasan_i(,) his_i mom thinks is sad.”

6.3 Summary

In this section, we have presented evidence to argue that the PIC, working in conspiracy with the WC, is an accurate predictor of the absence of hyperraising in Tamil, in line with our strong hypothesis in (54). We first presented evidence from overt reflexes of intermediate movement at Spec, CP supporting the idea that finite CPs are phasal and thus subject to the PIC. This means, concretely, that any movement out of the domain of a finite CP – such as subject movement out of Spec, TP – must necessarily pass through the phase edge at Spec, CP before moving into the higher clause. We showed next that where Spanish shows obligatory default agreement with hyperraising, a parallel construction with default agreement in Tamil necessarily diagnoses a subject in-situ structure where no hyperraising has occurred.

We have taken such negative evidence to show that that, unlike in Spanish, Tamil shows no evidence for a high subject position, above Spec, TP. This means

that hyperraising from the intermediate Spec, CP position in Tamil must necessarily target canonical subject position in matrix Spec, TP. But since T is lower than C on the clausal spine, such movement necessarily violates the WC. Hyperraising in Tamil thus necessarily runs afoul of either the PIC or the WC. Since violating either is disallowed, the sentence is unsalvageable and crashes.

7 Proposal: the ingredients of hyperraising

Consider our hypothesis in (54), repeated below:

- (71) Necessary input condition for a hyperraising language: Hyperraising(-to-subject) in some language *L* is possible only if long subject movement can obtain without violating the PIC or the WC (or both), in *L*.

An obvious advantage of the formulation in (71) is that it allows us to factor in typological variation with respect to hyperraising. Concretely, a language may allow hyperraising *either* because the clause that a subject hyperraises out of is non-phasal at the point of subject extraction or because subject A-movement out of the phase edge in Spec, CP is exceptionally possible without violating the WC, because of the availability of a subject position higher than, or at the same height as, the position of intermediate movement (e.g. Spec, CP) in the clausal functional sequence.

In other words, not every language allows hyperraising for the same reason; neither are the grounds for disallowing hyperraising the same across languages. The condition in (71) predicts, in fact, a four-way typology of languages with respect to this phenomenon, as illustrated below:

- (72) Four-way typology for hyperraising:¹⁴

Circumvents WC	Circumvents PIC	HR allowed?	Language
Yes	Yes	Yes	Spanish/Tiriki/Varieties of English
Yes	No	Yes	
No	Yes	Yes	Brazilian Portuguese/Zulu
No	No	No	Tamil

At the same time, while (71) is indeed a necessary condition for hyperraising to obtain in some language, it is by no means a sufficient one – the formulation of (71) accurately reflects this weaker conditional dependency. In other words, it is not the case that every language that obeys (71) necessarily also shows hyperraising. To this end, we present evidence showing that hyperraising may be disallowed in a given language because the (hyper)raising verb does not satisfy

¹⁴We are aware of no language that has been reported to simultaneously circumvent the PIC and the WC, but there is no reason such a language should not exist.

the relevant thematic conditions. Alternatively, hyperraising may be banned because the subject movement in question instantiates A-bar movement, and not A movement; this, we argue, is the case in V2 languages like Icelandic, German and others. Taken together, these data show that thematic considerations as well as the nature of subject movement must be factored in as relevant input conditions for hyperraising.

7.1 Thematic considerations

Like any other derivation, a hyperraising derivation must obey whatever other language-specific and universal grammatical constraints that apply elsewhere. In the domain of A-movement, one such constraint observed in a number of languages is the θ -criterion (Chomsky, 1981b), which we can describe as in (73) below:

(73) Theta-criterion: Argument $\leftrightarrow \theta$ -role

(73) states that every argument must be assigned exactly one theta-role and that every theta-role must be assigned to exactly one argument. Some proposals to the contrary (see e.g. the body of work underlying the movement theory of control, e.g. in Hornstein, 1999, et seq.) notwithstanding, the formulation in (73) has, by and large, been taken to restrict A-movement in syntax since at least Chomsky (1981b).

A further robust generalization across languages that allow raising/hyperraising is that the predicates that display the characteristic properties of *raising* are a proper subset of clausal-embedding predicates. More specifically, the predicates that permit raising tend to differ thematically from other clause-embedding predicates (e.g. control verbs) in not assigning a θ -role to their subjects. Indeed, the exceptional (putative) inability of a raising verb to assign a θ -role to the embedded subject is what is supposed to allow the subject to raise, in the first place.

Brazilian Portuguese (BP), a language argued to have both hyperraising and finite control verbs, allows us to tease apart thematic differences between predicates that do and do not permit hyperraising. In BP, hyperraising predicates constitute a proper subset of finite-CP-embedding predicates, as noted by Legate and Mendes (2024). Predicates like *parecer* ('seem') that successfully license hyperraising are set apart from the larger class of finite-CP-embedding predicates (which also includes finite control verbs) by a number of properties. First, hyperraising predicates like *parecer* do not assign a theta role to their subject, appear to genuinely allow movement of an argument from the clause they embed to their specifier. This is the case for predicates like *parecer* ('seem'), which observably (a) take athematic subjects and (b) allow A-movement across them. Property (a)

is observable from the fact that *parecer* can combine with zero-place predicates like *chover* ‘rain’ or existentials like *tem* (‘to be’):

- (74) Parece que choveu.
seems that rained
“It seems that it rained.” (web)
- (75) Parece que tem muita gente aqui.
seems that there.is much people here.
“It seems that there are a lot of people here.” (web)

Property (b) is observable from (i) the fact that cross-clausal dependencies involving *parecer* obligatorily require a gap, suggestive of a movement dependency, and (ii) the fact that the dependency obeys island constraints like the coordinate structure constraint (Ross (1967a)). This can be observed in the following data from Legate and Mendes (2024):

- (76) Alguma coisa parece que { EC / *ela } está errada com o meu
some thing seems that { EC / it } is wrong with my computer
computador.
(Anti-pronominal gap)
“It seems that something is wrong with my computer.”
- (77) *O João parece que comprou um carro e que a Maria alugou uma
the João seemed that bought a car and that the Maria rented a
casa.
house
Intended: “It seemed that João bought a car and that Maria rented a
house.” (Coordinate structure constraint)

On the other hand, cross-clausal A-dependencies with (finite) control verbs like *dizer* (‘to say’) display the opposite cluster of properties: they *do* assign a θ -role to their subject and do *not* display the same characteristics of movement mentioned above. First, note that these verbs are not compatible with weather or existential verbs according to our BP-speaking consultants:

- (78) *Diz que choveu.
says that rained
Intended: “It_i said that it_i rained.”
- (79) *Diz que tem muita gente aqui.
says that there.is much people here.
Intended: “There says / it is said that there are a lot of people here.”

Interestingly, when these verbs are involved in cross-clausal A-dependencies, they lack anti-pronominal gaps in the embedded clause and do not obey the coordinate structure constraint. This is again evident in the following data from Legate and Mendes (2024):

- (80) Alguma pessoa disse que ela tá chateada comigo.
 some person said that 3SG.F is annoyed with.me
 “Someone_i said that they_i’re annoyed with me.”
- (81) O João disse que comprou um carro e que a Maria alugou uma
 the João said that bought a car and that the Maria rented a
 casa.
 house.
 “João said that he bought a car and that Maria rented a house.”

Descriptively, this amounts to the following generalization: athematic raising is possible in Brazilian Portuguese (i.e. hyperraising) while thematic raising (= finite control derived via A-movement) is impossible. Such an asymmetry is familiar from the literature on non-finite clausal complements: while classic raising can be straightforwardly analyzed as movement, classic cases control still pose a number of issues for a movement analysis (e.g. the existence of partial control, the possibility of overt copies in the lower subject position, etc.; see Landau (2013) for an overview). With both finite control / hyperraising on the one hand and classic control/raising on the other, we see that movement into a thematic position is more restricted than movement into an athematic position.

While we remain agnostic about the precise way such a restriction should be encoded within or outside of syntax, its universality, etc., we note that it should in principle restrict hyperraising in a similar fashion to classic, non-finite raising; indeed, this is what we saw above for Brazilian Portuguese. Importantly, this case study also shows us that it’s possible for a given language to provide a path forward for complying with the Williams Cycle and Phase Impenetrability Condition, yet nonetheless still fail to license hyperraising over a particular predicate. This can happen if the relevant predicate assigns a θ -role to its external argument, assuming following the reasoning above that movement into θ -positions is restricted. A similar explanation is offered by Greeson (2024b), who argues that certain asymmetries between hyperraising predicates in Cantonese and Vietnamese noted by Lee and Yip (2023) may be attributable to the fact that the non-hyperraising predicates impose thematic restrictions on their subjects.

7.2 Hyperraising must involve A-movement

A second important consideration is that hyperraising must instantiate a species of A-movement. The movement may additionally bear reflexes of A-bar movement – indeed, as also discussed in Lohninger (2025), many (and potentially all) instances of hyperraising seem to involve mixed A/ $\bar{A}$ properties – but it cannot be purely a case of $\bar{A}$ movement. Here, we showcase this point by showing that hyperraising is notably absent in V2 languages like Icelandic: while Icelandic has a high landing position for a moved subject (i.e., high enough to be Williams Cycle-compliant), this movement does not involve A-properties.

V2 languages have been long observed to frequently host subjects in a higher-than-canonical position, in Spec, CP. Yet, many such languages do not allow hyperraising. Let us illustrate this using Icelandic, a V2 language that has also been reported to allow English-style classic raising-to-subject, as in (82):

- (82) Strákarnir eru taldir hafa verið kitlaðir.
 the boys.M.PL are.PL believed.M.PL.NOM to have been tickled.M.PL.NOM
 ‘The boys are believed to have been tickled.’ (Bobaljik and Landau, 2009, Ex. 3a, 115)

Nevertheless, Icelandic does not allow hyperraising:

- (83) *María (svo) virðist sem sé ánægð.
 Maria.NOM (like.that) seems COMP be.3SG.SUBJ happy.NOM.SG.F
 Intended: ‘It seems that María is happy.’ (Oddur Snorrason, p.c.)

Taken together, this constellation of patterns shows that being able to merge a subject in a high clausal position in a given language does not automatically entail that that language will manifest hyperraising.

We will now show that the movement of the subject to its high landing site in Icelandic is purely a case of $\bar{A}$ -movement. Convincing evidence in support of this comes from the fact that, while the movement targeting the high position in Icelandic (and other V2 languages like German) can target DPs (cf. also (84)), it does not exclusively do so; e.g. in (85), this position is occupied by a complex adverbial (Angantýsson, 2017, Exx. 1a, c, 55):

- (84) Ég hef í hreinskilni sagt aldrei séð refi á þessum slóðum.
 I have honestly said never seen foxes in this area
 ‘I have honestly never seen foxes in this area.’
 (85) Í hreinskilni sagt hef ég aldrei séð refi á þessum slóðum.
 honestly said have I never seen foxes in this area.

Under the featural definition of A-movement that we are assuming, following Van Urk (2015), A-movement is movement driven by an A-feature, which includes only those features which are unique to arguments/nominals, including

but not limited to ϕ , [D], and potentially Case. No such A-feature could be implicated in a class of movement that targets adverbials alongside arguments, as is the case for V2 sentences in Icelandic. Hence, this high V2 position is not a landing site for A-movement, including hyperraising.

At the same time, it is important to note that there is nothing intrinsic to the property of being a V2 language per se that makes it incompatible with hyperraising. In other words, if a language is V2 and V2 movement of the subject to Spec, CP is, in fact, a case of A-movement, then we do expect such a language to allow hyperraising. Dinka seems to be precisely such a language. Like Icelandic, Dinka allows displacement of material from various positions in the clause to a high sentence-initial position, but unlike Icelandic, Dinka forces the displaced material to be a DP. Consider the following minimal pair from Van Urk (2015):

- (86) Àyén à-càm cuîn nè paal.
 Ayen 3s-eat.sv food p knife.
 “Ayen is eating food with a knife.”
- (87) Paal à-cèémè Áyèn cuîn.
 knife 3s-eat.OBLV Ayen.GEN food
 “With a knife, Ayen is eating food.”

In (86), *paal* (‘knife’) remains *in situ* and is contained within a PP. When *paal* is promoted to Spec,CP as in (87), it obligatorily appears as a preposition-less DP that triggers oblique voice on the verb in V2 position. Unlike in Icelandic and other Germanic V2 languages, Dinka only allows DPs in sentence-initial position in V2 sentences. This is consistent with the displacement in (87) actually being a type of A-movement (more specifically, hybrid A/ $\bar{A}$ movement) as argued in Van Urk (2015). If one of the probes on C triggering movement to its specifier is an A-probe like ϕ , this behavior is expected. As Van Urk (2015) also shows, Dinka generally allows this same type of mixed A/ $\bar{A}$ movement to cross finite clause boundaries. This essentially makes Dinka a ‘generalized’ hyperraising language, of sorts: in particular, Dinka not only allows A-movement of subjects across finite clause boundaries (hyperraising), but also of other DPs.¹⁵

7.3 Summary: final input conditions for HR

On the strength of the discussion above, we will now propose the updated input conditions for hyperraising in (88) below:

¹⁵Coppe van Urk (p.c.) informs us that he is aware of no evidence from Dinka which counter-exemplifies the view that hyperraising is a special case of the kind of cross-clausal A/ $\bar{A}$ dependency attested in this language.

- (88) Hyperraising(-to-subject) in some language L is possible if and only if, in L :
- i. long subject-movement can obtain without violating the PIC or the WC (or both), and;
 - ii. the raising predicate does not assign a θ -role to the moved subject, and;
 - iii. subject movement to its landing site involves A-features.

(88) allows us to predict a crosslinguistic typology with respect to hyperraising. There are many ways for a language L to violate the input conditions in (88); however, there is only one way for it to satisfy them, namely by conjunctively obeying all the input conditions in (88). As such, (88) also accurately predicts the rarity of hyperraising crosslinguistically. We are aware of no counter-examples to (88) at the time of writing. We will thus take the strong position that (88) describes the necessary and sufficient conditions for hyperraising crosslinguistically.

8 Troubleshooting: ν P phasehood and (hyper)raising-to-object

In this section, we troubleshoot two possible objections to the input conditions given in (88) and to the Williams Cycle (as formulated in (31)) more broadly: namely, hyperraising-to-object and ν P phasehood. We examine the nature of evidence typically provided in the literature in support of both but conclude that this same evidence could, in theory, be analyzed in a way that is compliant with our proposal and with the WC, more broadly.

8.1 Raising- & hyperraising-to-object

An obvious empirical challenge for implementing any version of the Williams Cycle is the existence of certain constructions like (89), often called ‘raising-to-object’ (RtO) sentences or ‘exceptional case marking’ (ECM) sentences, depending on one’s analysis. We will henceforth refer to these as ‘accusative-with-infinitive’ constructions so as not to presuppose a particular theory of their derivation.

- (89) Hasan expects her to win.

Canonical accusative-with-infinitive constructions involve an argument (*her* in (89)) that is the thematic subject of the embedded verb, but in many ways behaves like a matrix object. For example, as (89) shows, the infinitival subject

her bears accusative case. Furthermore, for accusative-with-infinitive predicates that consist of a verb and particle, the particle can occur *after* the accusative argument, providing an even stronger for its position in the matrix clause (see Postal 1974). Similarly, a matrix adverbial like *sincerely* can intervene between the accusative argument and the rest of the embedded clause (91).

(90) Hasan **made** her **out** to have won the race.

(91) Hasan believed her sincerely to have won the race.

For this and other reasons, the prevailing analysis of these constructions maintains that the dependency involves movement (see Polinsky 2013 for a contemporary overview). Under the raising analysis, constructions like (92) involve movement from embedded Spec,TP to the complement position of matrix V. Since V is lower than T in the functional sequence, this violates the Williams Cycle.

(92) [_{TP} John expects her [_{TP} ~~her~~ to win]]. (raising-to-object)

However, cross-clausal A-movement is not the only way to analyze these ‘raising-to-object’ sentences. One alternative analysis, dating back to Chomsky (1981a), is the exceptional case marking, or ECM, analysis. Under this view, the subject of the embedded non-finite TP is ‘exceptionally’ assigned accusative case by the matrix verb, though it remains *in situ* in the embedded clause. Such an analysis has mostly fallen out of favor, largely because it makes data like (90) especially puzzling. However, recent work by Neeleman and Payne (2020) revisits the accusative-with-infinitive construction and advocates for a ‘neglected alternative analysis’ wherein the word order observed in (92) is derived via rightward extraposition of *to have won* rather than promotion of the embedded subject *her* to the matrix clause. Neeleman & Payne use experimental evidence to show that in the few cases where the empirical predictions of the raising analysis and the non-raising extraposition analysis differ (e.g. linear order of stacked adverbs, scope of the accusative argument), speakers’ judgments uniformly pattern with the predictions of the rightward-extraposition analysis. As discussed in Poole (2023), this analysis offers a promising way forward for analyzing accusative-with-infinitive constructions in a Williams Cycle-compliant way.

Arguably more problematic for our proposal are purported cases of hyperraising-to-object across an overt complementizer. Recall that Spanish has been argued to allow hyperraising-to-object in sentences like (6), repeated below in (94) from Herbeck (2020):

(93) Vi que María estaba enferma.
saw.1SG that María was sick
“I saw that María was sick.” (No displacement)

- (94) Vi a María que María estaba enferma.
 saw.1SG DOM María that María was sick.
 “I saw that María was sick.” (HRtO)

Unlike the accusative-with-infinitive examples, it’s not possible to derive the attested word order via a single instance of rightward extraposition—the intervening material between the accusative argument and the embedded predicate is a complementizer, which unlike adverbs and particles is unambiguously merged *above* the embedded subject.

However, since Spanish allows *pro*-drop, the so-called “hyperraising-to-object” sentence above is actually ambiguous between a true hyperraising-to-object derivation and a non-movement analysis where embedded *pro* is bound by *María* (perhaps similar to prolepsis, cf. Salzmann 2017). To tease apart these possibilities, we consulted 3 Spanish speakers to compare judgments of the subject-to-subject hyperraising islands reported in Fernández-Salgueiro (2005) in (95) to island configurations in the hypothesized hyperraising-to-object construction (96). Crucially, our informants reported island effects to be absent in the latter: The results are as given below:

- (95) *Juan y Pedro parece [_{CP} que Eva se pregunta si —
 Juan and Pedro seem-3SG.PRES [_{CP} that Eva 3SG.REFL ask-3SG.PRES if —
 se marcharon].
 left-3PL.PAST]
 Intended: “It seems that Eva wonders whether Juan and Pedro left.” (Fernández Salgueiro 2005)
- (96) Voy a ver a María [_{CP} si — se marchó].
 Go-1SG.PRES to see-PRES DOM María [_{CP} if — left]
 “I’m going to see if María left” (OK direct perception, # indirect).

Since, to our knowledge, all hyperraising languages thus far described in the literature (both HR to object and HR to subject) are *pro*-drop languages, hyperraising-to-object would be superficially identical to a non-movement derivation in which an embedded null subject *pro* is bound by a matrix argument (e.g. copy raising, or prolepsis). Given the lack of island effects in the Spanish examples above, we suggest that this is the case at least for Spanish.¹⁶

¹⁶Note: prolepsis is considered as an alternative analysis and ruled out for Nez Perce HRtO in Deal (2017), so while the *pro*-drop counter-analysis is viable for Spanish, it is not for Nez Perce. Further consideration of the Nez Perce data is necessary for future work that assumes the Williams Cycle—we merely note here that *one* way to re-analyze purported cases of hyperraising-to-object is prolepsis with a covert embedded argument, not that this is the only way. For Nez Perce, given the covert and semantically-motivated nature of hyperraising-to-object under Deal’s

8.2 ν P phasehood

Another question concerns whether the ν P involved in raising/hyperraising constructions is also subject to the PIC. We assume, following evidence from Hirsch (2011) and elsewhere, that the little ν associated with raising verbs patterns with passive ν and unaccusative ν in being non-phasal. Hence, there is no need for movement to pass through Spec, ν P as an intermediate step in hyperraising. But the issue of little ν P phasehood poses a larger problem for the Williams Cycle extending beyond the case of raising verbs, which exceptionally do not combine with phasal ν . In general, if the Williams Cycle is right, then both ν P and CP phasehood cannot simultaneously require movement through their edges: CP to ν P movement violates the Williams Cycle. We follow previous authors in assuming that at most one of these is actually a phase/requires intermediate movement through its Spec, usually discarding ν P phasehood and providing alternative analyses for apparent cases of successive cyclic movement through spec, ν P (Poole 2023, Keine 2017, 2020; Keine and Zeijlstra 2025).

9 Conclusion

The present study has been an exercise in scrutinizing and refining the input conditions for hyperraising. We have shown that a number of constraints previously proposed as the chief factors regulating hyperraising cannot suffice on their own to explain its absence in Tamil or its crosslinguistic distribution more broadly. First, despite prior work advocating a key role for Activity (e.g. Nunes 2008), we showed that Activity makes no useful predictions about hyperraising in Tamil—(a), because non-finite raising is optional, and (b), because finiteness is not a reliable predictor of case assignment more generally in Tamil. Second, we considered whether A-over-A configurations of the type described in Minimality-based analyses (Halpert 2019a, Halpert and Zeijlstra 2024) play an important role in ruling out hyperraising in Tamil, but found display the opposite behavior of what’s expected under a “Minimality only” approach to licensing hyperraising: despite the *non-intervener* status of the embedded CP in ungrammatical hyperraising constructions, hyperraising is still impossible.

After rejecting an alternative view where only Activity and/or Minimality regulate hyperraising, we showed that the *height* of the potential landing site for a hyperraised subject, acting together with phasehood, is a key factor that allows hyperraising in a number of languages. Together with the conclusion

(2017) proposal, one possible way forward is to posit that this movement happens at LF, and that the Williams Cycle is a constraint on narrowly syntactic operations only. Such an approach to handling Williams Cycle exceptions is discussed in Meadows (2024).

that finite CPs are phasal in Tamil, such an approach correctly predicts hyper-raising to be ruled out in this language. We have taken these facts to support an approach to hyperraising in terms of the Williams Cycle/Generalized Ban on Improper Movement, defined as in (31), acting in conspiracy with the Phase Impenetrability Condition (PIC) as in (28). At the same time, we have shown that the WC + PIC approach is not, on its own, a sufficient predictor of the availability of hyperraising crosslinguistically. We have proposed that, in addition, hyperraising must involve a species of A-movement to an athematic position.

Together, our investigation has led us to propose (88), repeated below, describing the ingredients that we believe to be both necessary and sufficient for hyperraising to obtain in a given language:

- (97) Hyperraising(-to-subject) in some language L is possible if and only if, in L :
- i. long subject-movement can obtain without violating the PIC or the WC (or both), and;
 - ii. the raising predicate does not assign a θ -role to the moved subject, and;
 - iii. subject movement to its landing site involves A-features.

(97) states that a language L must conjunctively obey all three input conditions and, furthermore, takes the strong position that these are the only input conditions such a language need obey, to manifest hyperraising. This in turn, explains the crosslinguistic infrequency of this phenomenon: in short, there are many more ways to violate (97) than to obey it. If future research uncovers that a language bans hyperraising despite obeying these conditions or if it, conversely, shows that a language allows hyperraising despite not obeying one or more of them, then our formulation in (97) will have been shown to be incorrect, incomplete, or both.

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